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STARDOM FOR SALE

AT TALENT CONVENTIONS FOR KIDS, FAMILIES BUY IN AND LOSE OUT

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As Easy as 1, 2, 3?

Activists Campaign for Ranked-Choice Voting in Maine

BY **MOLLY SHAPIRO**

WHEN CARTOGRAPHER NICOLE GROHOSKI is not making maps or studying for her wilderness first responder test, she is standing outside in freezing temperatures, collecting signatures. Grohoski's boss accommodates her unpredictable schedule because he too believes in the cause: a new voting system for the state of Maine.

Grohoski resolved to look for an alternative voting system after the gubernatorial election in 2014, when current Republican Governor Paul LePage, who was running against two other candidates, won with 48.2 percent of the vote. For Mainers, a governor without majority support was nothing new: The last time a first-term governor won the majority of votes was in 1966.

"I thought, 'This seems a little interesting, that we are consistently electing people that don't have a majority or 50 percent of the vote." Grohoski told *The Politic*. "Is there a better way?'"

The 34-year-old did some research and quickly discovered that there were, indeed, alternatives. One option Grohoski came across especially stood out to her: the beginnings of a campaign to implement ranked-choice voting in Maine elections.

In a ranked-choice voting system, as the name suggests, voters rank all candidates. During vote tabulation, first choices are counted, and the candidate who wins the majority of them is the winner. But if no candidate has won a majority of those first votes, the candidate who earned the fewest first choice votes is eliminated, and ballots are adjusted accordingly. If voters put the eliminated candidate first, their second-choice candidate assumes the first place spot on their ballot. The counting process is repeated until a candidate earns the majority of votes.

Word of the proposed voting system quickly spread across Maine. In a 2016 referendum, ranked-choice voting received 52 percent of voter support, a higher share of the vote than Maine's past governors.

But the victory was short-lived. Only several months after the passage of the referendum, Maine's Supreme Court released an advisory opinion which stated that the voter-approved law was unconstitutional for state general elections. (The Court did not object to the use of ranked-choice voting in federal elections and state primaries.)

Because the Court's opinion was advisory, not binding, it was up to the Maine Legislature to make the next move. The legislature had three options: to repeal the voter-approved law that would implement ranked-choice voting, to pass a constitutional amendment that would resolve issues that make ranked-choice voting unconstitutional in state general elections, or to implement ranked-choice voting for only federal elections and state primaries.

In October 2017, after much debate, Maine's Senate voted to delay the law's implementation until December 2021, at which point the legislatures would repeal it if they still have not passed a constitutional amendment addressing the Court's legal concerns. Until then, Maine will keep its current voting system.

"People were excited," Crystal Canney, a spokesperson for the Committee for Ranked Choice Voting, told *The Politic*. "It was a clear directive from the people. And then the legislature came in and they tried to take the power

away from the people."

Kyle Bailey, the Campaign Manager of the Committee for Ranked Choice Voting, called the bill "the ultimate slap in the face from politicians who think they know better than people." Still, he told *The Politic* that the bill did not come as a surprise.

"You have politicians making calculated choices about their own political careers," Bailey said. "For them, that trumps the desires of the people."

But Mainers were not ready to accept defeat. The state's constitution granted them another weapon: the "people's veto." Proponents of ranked-choice voting had 90 days as of November 6 to get 61,123 signatures from Mainers who wanted to reject the delay-and-repeal law passed by the legislature in October.

"The 'people's veto' gave us an opportunity to come back and say, we do understand what we voted for. We like what we voted for," Canney said.

Over the past several months, Mainers have mobilized. Grohoski said that she and her parents braved subzero temperatures and collected over 1,000 signatures in four counties. In Blue Hill, a wine shop advertises the petition. At the Bal Harbour movie theater, petitioners are on rotation. A band wrote a song about ranked-choice voting and sang it at a brewing company in Southern Maine. Over the phone, a 94-year-old asked volunteers to drive to her house so that she and her husband could sign the petition.

"The grassroots support is like nothing I've seen before," said Bailey, who volunteered for the 2012 same-sex marriage campaign in Maine. He compared the ranked-choice organizing efforts to the marriage equality movement of six years ago. "I venture to say there are more volunteers in this effort than in that one."

Why does a voting system inspire such overwhelming support? Many proponents believe that ranked-choice voting would give Maine's many third-party candidates a better chance at getting elected. Ranked-choice voting could eliminate the spoiler effect—when votes for independent party candidates disproportionately benefit a major party candidate. With this system in place, ranked-choice advocates say, voters would be free to pick their first choice candidate without limiting themselves to major-party candidates.

"You should never have to vote for the lesser of two evils when there's another candidate you really like," Bailey said. "You should be free to vote your hopes and not your fears."

Ranked-choice voting might also make campaigns more civil, by incentivizing candidates to reach beyond their base instead of criticizing their opponents. Each candidate will vie to be voters' second choice, if not their first.

What's more, supporters contend that ranked-choice voting could lead to more effective governance.

"I think the American public, as well as the Maine people, have taken a hard look at some of the partisanship that's gone on and how hard it is to get things done," Canney said. "This is the first step to righting that system."

Matt Dunlap, the Secretary of State of Maine, who is responsible for certifying the tabulation of election results, is not convinced by these arguments. Like many members of the Maine legislature, Dunlap has concerns about ranked-choice voting.



PHOTOS COURTESTY OF **THE COMMITTEE FOR RANKED CHOICE VOTING**

Dunlap acknowledged the polarization in American politics. In his view, though, the problem is not the voting system, but the people running for office.

"The easy solution is to get better candidates that generate more consensus," Dunlap told *The Politic.*

Dunlap called the suggestion that campaigns would become less adversarial "laughable."

"What's going to happen is the outside money is going to amplify even more and proxies will crap all over your opponents for you," he said.

Dunlap claimed the system would be challenging to implement, too. He said that the legislature will likely not approve funding for ranked-choice voting, leaving the states without the machinery to efficiently tabulate votes. Determining election results could take as long as two weeks.

"I apologize if it sounds like I'm deadly opposed to ranked-choice voting, but these are the things that nobody seems to think about. I wish people would stop saying how easy it is. Because administratively, there's a lot that goes into this that nobody sees to take seriously, but when it all goes wrong, the bright lights are gonna be on me, and I'm gonna be alone in that room," Dunlap said.

To cartographer-turned-activist Grohoski, Dunlap's insistence on the system's complexity is exasperating.

"My message to the Secretary of State is, we sometimes have to do things in our job that are hard and that we don't like," Grohoski said.

Bailey called Dunlap's suggestion that the voting system is too complicated to implement "frankly absurd."

"It's not grounded in any factual information or any experience of any city or county or state that we've seen in this country use rank choice voting," he said.

Bailey cited North Carolina's successful statewide pilot project for ranked-choice voting in 2010.

Dunlap has little patience for references to other places that have implemented ranked-choice voting.

"There's a saying in this business that if you know how elections are managed in your state, then you know how elections are managed in *your* state," he said. "Election law in North Carolina is very, very different."

But the Secretary is well aware that he has no real say in the matter.

"I'm not a policy-maker, I'm an administrator. So my job really is to do what I'm told," Dunlap said "Now, that being said, you don't want to be told to do the impossible."

It remains to be seen whether ranked-choice voting will work for Maine. If the "people's veto" is successful, and petitioners obtain the requisite number of signatures by February 2nd, Mainers will employ ranked-choice voting in the June primary election. They will also vote on whether to veto the delay-and-repeal bill. If the majority of Mainers vote to veto the bill, ranked-choice voting will be used in primary and federal elections from then on.

Ranked-choice advocates would see this outcome as a triumph for democracy, not only because of the reform it would entail, but how it was achieved—through the tireless work of passionate citizens who persisted in spite of interference from the judiciary, the legislature, and the freezing temperatures.

"This is a transformative reform that could improve our democracy," Bailey said. "It's not a silver bullet. But it's one thing we can do and we ought to do to give voters more voice and more choice in our democracy. To me, that's exciting."



Not a Winter Wonderland

A Steep Slope of Inequality at Ski Resorts



PHOTOS BY **KATHY MIN**

BY **KATHY MIN**

"The evidence is very clear that resort communities, like mu very challenging jobs for limited pay and limited social safe

"I DON'T THINK HE SPEAKS English," an employee at the Shore Lodge resort hotel in McCall, Idaho, said to me. She gave an apologetic smile, whispering as if her words were incongruous with the opulence of Shore Lodge. The employee, who worked in guest services, was referring to a janitor to my left, who was silently sweeping the floor beside the majestic view of Lake Payette.

Shore Lodge was the last stop on my three-day foray into McCall, a ski resort town two hours north of my hometown, Boise. I had traveled with my family over winter break to enjoy McCall's abundance of winter recreation: skiing, snowmobiling, snow tubing, ice skating, and relaxing in hot springs. McCall, a small ski resort town often compared to an early version of the more glamorous Sun Valley, was what locals like to call a "hidden gem"— known to Idahoans like me, but not to many others.

Shore Lodge, described to me as the "anchor" of McCall, has a subdued extravagance: The exterior is rustic and adorned with Christmas decorations; the lobby, with warm light illuminating its cabin-like architecture, faces the rippling vastness of Lake Payette. In many ways, Shore Lodge mirrors the cozy luxury of McCall as a whole.

Yet, the quiet presence of Shore Lodge's immigrant workforce—the first time I had seen immigrants at all in McCall—illustrated the less cheerful side of the town, and it epitomized the contradictory identity of ski resort towns more generally. Behind the natural beauty and manufactured glitz lie uncomfortable realities: Immigrant communities face dramatic inequality, housing costs are exorbitant, and mental health issues are swept under the rug.

The invisibility of immigrants is not exclusive to McCall. Ski resort towns in the U.S. have become what sociologists Patrick Carr, Daniel Lichter, and Maria Kefalas have termed "Hispanic boomtowns." These are small towns that have witnessed an influx of immigrants from Central and South America; in the Jackson, Wyoming ski resort town, for example, approximately 30 percent of people are Hispanic. In McCall, the Hispanic population has increased by more than 200 percent over the last decade, although Hispanics still represent a small share of the population. Even as the number of immigrants has increased in ski resort communities, their presence sometimes remains understated.



"When you visit a resort town in Colorado or the Mountain West, it's clear that there are many people from immigrant communities who are keeping the restaurants and ski shops and all the other facilities in town," said Abraham Nussbaum, the chief education officer at Denver Health, in an interview with *The Politic*. He added that immigrants "often are living in sort of secluded or hidden part of town, in very close quarters."

David Pellow, the Dehlsen Chair of Environmental Studies at the University of California, Santa Barbara, and author of *The Slums of Aspen*, has extensively researched immigrants in ski resort communities. In an interview with *The Politic*, he first clarified that the immigrant experience is far from homogenous.

"There's a diversity of experiences and viewpoints within immigrant communities," said Pellow.

Some immigrants move to the mountains to escape conflict or poverty in their home countries; others search for the classic offerings of a ski resort town: clean air, outdoor recreation, small town serenity.

Considering the multiplicity of immigrant experiences, Pellow acknowledged that many immigrants—particularly those who are undocumented—do not fully enjoy the advertised luxury of ski resorts.

"Life for [many immigrants] is fundamentally different than a tourist or wealthy resident," Pellow explained.

Pellow recalled a "poignant" moment interviewing a Mexican immi-

ch of America, are powered by immigrants who work often ty nets."



LOLO NELSON, LEFT, AND CINDY JONES, RIGHT, AT MCCALL REAL ESTATE COMPANY

grant who worked in Aspen, Colorado, a popular ski resort city. When asked about the Aspen Mountains, tourists raved to him about the environment, calling it a "refreshing weekend away from Wall Street." In that particular interview, though, the Mexican immigrant simply replied, "What mountains?" For this immigrant, Pellow reflected, working in Aspen had little to do with the scenery so venerated by other tourists; it was a job.

"Immigrants are there to work and service as the engine of the local economy, and so central to that society and economy, and yet despised. And that's the narrative we see nationally as well," Pellow said.

As an example, he referenced a 1999 Aspen City Council resolution calling for restricted immigration. The official purpose of the resolution was to control population growth and its ensuing ecological harms.

But immigrant workers are essential contributors to ski resort towns. "The evidence is very clear that resort communities, like much of America, are powered by immigrants who work often very challenging jobs for limited pay and limited social safety nets," Pellow explained.

One study from the Colorado Fiscal Institute found that Hispanic populations were more likely to hold low-wage jobs in Colorado than other demographic groups.

High housing costs in areas surrounding exclusive ski resorts further exacerbate inequality for these workers.

"What we see in Aspen and the Roaring Fork Valley is what we see in other parts of the country and the world," Pellow explained, "where low-wage earning residents and immigrants have to pool their resources. Many people have to live under a single roof to make ends meet and pay rent."

For McCall residents with less affluent backgrounds, securing affordable housing is the most pressing issue. Anna Loseki works at Activity Barn, a tubing company in McCall. Loseki said one of the difficulties of working in McCall was "just trying to find housing that's affordable, especially working here, which is not the best pay."

Loseki lives in Cascade in her grandmother's house.

"Lower income houses are really, really hard to find, especially in a place that is convenient to get to work in town," Loseki said, noting that she had to drive about 45 minutes each day for work.

Cindy Jones and her coworker Lolo Nelson are agents at the McCall

Real Estate Company. According to Nelson, long commutes are a common response to prohibitive housing costs.

"[Housing costs are] definitely a problem for the workforce," Nelson noted. "And a lot of people drive from Council or even Cascade to work here." Council, Idaho, is a 50-minute drive from McCall. Cascade is 40 minutes away.

TJ Brady, another employee at Shore Lodge in guest services, told me, "Housing is the biggest obstacle. There's not a shortage of jobs, just affordable housing."

As much as he loves the outdoors, without a special employee housing program offered by Shore Lodge, Brady isn't sure he will be staying in McCall.

"Rentals are sky high," he said.

"We've always been a higher price point, that's for sure, because we are a resort town," Jones remarked. "During the boom, our prices were higher than homes in Boise…in McCall proper you have to be at least 200, 250 [thousand dollars]. There's not too much here for under two [hundred thousand dollars]." According to Jones, some McCall residents afford the high housing costs by taking multiple jobs.

The prohibitive housing costs can deter potential workers from moving to McCall, resulting in a shortage of labor. "There are several businesses that can't be open because they don't have enough help," she said.



But the majority of people living in McCall are short-term residents.

"McCall is mostly a second home market," Nelson said. "Some are permanent residents, but most are buying a second home."

"Or a third," Jones added, chuckling.

Many second homeowners are what Jones calls "town shoppers."

"We see a lot of people that are retiring. They are town shoppers. They want a smaller town, they want a place with recreation, clean air, clean water," she said."So that drives our community." Jones saw the combination of small town familiarity and natural beauty drawing wealthier residents to McCall.

"I think what people with money like about McCall is that it's quiet money," Jones said. "It's not mansions, the big star power. People that are well-known like that."

McCall is not the only resort community with such dramatic disparities of wealth. Other glitzy resorts, like Jackson Hole, are home to the highest rates of income inequality in the U.S.

Although Jones and Nelson noted that the McCall City Council was taking steps, including affordable housing measures, to reduce inequality, Pellow argued that there were no simple solutions.

"What makes these resorts so ecologically unsustainable is the housing that is built to support the tourist economy," he said.

"They pollute the landscape, they pollute the water, they require the amplification on the fossil fuel economy, placing all sorts of pressures on the local ecosystem and thriving off of local housing values and prices. It's the tourist economy that increases the ability of outsiders who are wealthy to come in and enjoy themselves, and conversely, decreases the ability of locals to find places that are livable and

affordable," he explained.

Along with housing inequality, ski resort communities are afflicted with disproportionately high rates of mental illness and suicide; McCall, along with other ski resorts, resides in what is known as the "Suicide Belt." Perry Renshaw, a professor of psychiatry at the University of Utah School of Medicine, noted, "We saw this great map of suicides across the United States, and the Rocky Mountain states line up, reflecting much higher rates of suicide in the Rocky Mountain states."

In 2015, Idaho's suicide rate was the fifth-highest in the country, 57 percent higher than the national average. Blaine County, which houses the famed Sun Valley Resort, has a suicide rate 17 percent higher than Idaho's. Ski resorts across the Rocky Mountains tell a similar story: Suicide rates from Aspen, Salt Lake County (with ski resorts in Alta and Snowbird), and Telluride are as high as six times the national average.

Nussbaum from Denver Health noted a range of factors that contribute to high rates of mental illness in ski resort communities.

First, economic inequality aggravates the obstacles other rural communities traditionally face. "The challenges for resort towns, especially in the Mountain West, is that they are in rural communities that have all of the usual challenges of rural communities, with the additional challenge that the cost of living in those towns is prohibitively expensive," Nussbaum said.

Low social cohesion is a factor as well. While several McCall residents commented on the beauty of small town culture, Nussbaum noted its isolation.

"Resort communities have decreased civic third spaces: places like churches or synagogues or other places of worship. They tend to have decreased fraternal organization. There aren't as many places for people to interact that might build up the community and prevent some of the serious mental health concerns that we see being prevalent in resort towns," Nussbaum explained.

Even though social activities in McCall can revolve around the outdoors, Loseki believes they were insufficient in creating a larger sense of community. "It's not like a wine tasting event, which if you do that, you meet more people. Hiking is like a solo group. You stay in your group," she said.

Loseki also commented on the difficulty of forming community in McCall. "I think it can be challenging, especially as a young adult, to make friends or have that social life, because there's not a whole lot to do. Especially if you're new, I can't imagine coming in. There is that tight-knit community and then coming in as an outsider, there's not a whole lot of opportunities to insert yourself in the community."

But according to Jones and Nelson, McCall's small town charm is what sets it apart. "Our community is great. You can't go to the grocery store without seeing someone you know. And you can't not love that small town feeling," Jones smiled.

What's more, Renshaw, of the University of Utah, argued that altitude changes could have an effect on mental health. According to Renshaw, as altitude increases, serotonin production decreases. Crucial steps in the pathway for serotonin production require oxygen, which decreases in higher altitudes. Indeed, the link between serotonin and mental health is well studied: Less serotonin correlates with greater rates of depression and suicide.

Although some have criticized Renshaw's studies as overly simplistic, Renshaw acknowledged that suicide is often due to myriad variables. Still, he isolated altitude as a risk factor. "We have done many analyses, and even when you account for other variables, altitude still pops up as a risk factor for suicide. In the last five years, [case studies from] Austria, Spain, Saudi Arabia, Chile, Peru, South Korea…show the exact same thing. You go up in altitude, suicide and depression go up."

My most vivid memory of McCall was the drive: Along the road, endless soaring trees and pristine white snow formed a backdrop of silent serenity. Was this the McCall everyone else saw? And after I visited, I wondered, should this be the McCall we see?

Uncovering the McCall that strayed from its idyllic imagery was a laborious process of reading between blurred lines. Most people I spoke to gushed over the friendliness of the community, of enjoying the great outdoors, of their dreams of building a family in McCall.

One journalist I spoke to asked me why I chose to focus on McCall, when it was not as famous or renowned as other ski resorts, the inequalities not as drastic, and the information not as widely available. Undoubtedly, McCall is not Jackson Hole or Vail or even Sun Valley.

But disregarding McCall seemed worse. Simply because the disparities and difficulties smaller communities face are not always obvious does not mean the problems do not exist. If few knew McCall existed at all, even fewer would believe that McCall was less than paradise. And to me, this brand of willful ignorance is also an act of forgetting, dangerously and unjustifiably so.

ART ON WHEELS

Painting Pakistan's Truck "Brides"

BY **AYLA KHAN**



PHOTOS BY **AYLA KHAN**

DRIVING THROUGH the streets of Karachi, Pakistan, you see bold graffiti covering the walls, trash lining the streets, and people crouching on cement sidewalks. Throngs of locals sit outside street cafes, sipping *chai* in *dhabas* under the scorching sun. The commotion in the street fills your ears as frustrated drivers hurl insults into the dusty, humid air and incessantly honk their horns. Trucks stand out against the traffic—their bodies heavily embellished with paint and shiny strips. The riveting combination of colors swirls before your eyes, following you until you reach Keamari port.

Keamari is the largest port in the province of Sindh, where Karachi is located. It is famous for trade and transport of fresh seafood and crafts. Bedford trucks transport manufactured and non-perishable goods such as *masalas* and dry fruit throughout Pakistan. These trucks trace their roots back to the British automaker Vauxhall Motors, which exported them to Pakistan after World War I. The Maripur neighborhood surrounding Keamari Port has six "gates" for trucks: vast, open spaces where thousands of trucks are constructed, painted, and decorated. The scorching sun beats down on a gate that reads "3." As you walk through it, a canvas of neon colors greets you. Trucks are lined up, in various stages of being painted, repaired, and glossed.

The "brides," as the trucks are called by their owners, are adorned in exquisite jewellery. Metallic elements dipped in gold varnish hang by their

sides like earrings. The windshield forms the truck's "eyes," above which rests a *taj*. Below the truck's windshield is a garland of flowers. The exterior is a riot of colors.

For a truck's owner, a "bride" is not just a romantic partner or wife; she is also his shelter and source of comfort. On one side of the "bride," there is a ladder, which leads up to the cab, On the backside of one truck, there is an image of a man with his arms raised at his sides. He is clad in a loose frock, with a shawl draped over his shoulders. His jet-black hair matches his beard and flows past his shoulders. There is solace in his dreamy eyes. *Tasbeehs, prayer beads,* hang from both his arms—a reminder of religious faith. The man is a Sufi saint. Peach and brown shades blend to form his face. Beside him are lines of poetry in Persian or Urdu. Each italicized word is transcribed carefully.

According to Zehra Nawab, author of the book *Seeking Paradise: The Image and Reality of Truck Art,* the figure most commonly depicted on trucks is Syed Abdul Qadir Jilani, a revered 12th-century Sufi, who is featured in several legends. Sufi traditions are embedded deeply in the minds of Pakistan's lower class.

Witty sentences and beautiful Arabic poetry form the majority of calligraphy. Also common are painted jasmines, the national flower of Pakistan, that blossom in all their glory. Other trucks display idyllic depictions of landscapes in northern Pakistan, where the mountains sleep like giants who have lost their way.

In Gate 6, the welder Ejaz explained to me why the trucks are painted. Not only do the decorations provide occupations for illiterate people with a family history of artisanry, he said, but they also increase the truck's resale value.

"The painted surfaces also take time to wear away," he said.

A crowd of men gathered around, eager to share their knowledge about their work.

These men dress their trucks in shiny geometric patterns, which are made out of strips of an indigenous material known as "'*chamak patti*" in Urdu. Their trucks are a cacophony of glimmering mirrors and neon colors.

In one of the many little shops situated around the gate, shopkeepers Bilal and Qamar explained the art of carving *"chamak patti."* Both have been in the trade for twenty years. For the first ten, they worked in their father's and uncle's shop, learning how to glue pieces of the bright material together to form unique designs. They also polished and sculpted the metal earrings that hang off the trucks. For

For a truck's owner, a "bride" is not just a romantic partner or wife; she is also his shelter and source of comfort.



the past ten years, they have operated out of their own shop, supplying materials that drivers can glue, paste, and display on their trucks.

"We use pictures taken from people's phones as references," said Bilal, excited to explain his work.

In recent years, the pair has begun to digitally print pictures on different materials and paste them onto pieces of metal to form decorations.

A painter's muscular arm moves across the truck, an empty canvas. The green of a verdant garden, the brown of fresh mud, the burgundy of a bird's neck—suddenly the entire truck is covered with colors, memories, and ideas. Who is the man behind the brush?

Imran said in an interview that he, like most other painters, has never known any other occupation. His father and grandfather were truck artists, and as a young child, he was an apprentice to a teacher of the craft, or *ustaad*. With thick swirls and brushes of white paint, he transcribes a poetic Urdu verse that reads, "mother's prayer, heaven's air," onto the truck.

"You know the way you go to school?" he said. "This is school for us."

When he began his apprenticeship as a teenager, Imran was illiterate. After fifteen years of learning calligraphy-based painting, he is now proficient in both reading and writing. His arm moved skillfully in quick swishes over the metal surface. He said that he is used to working quickly, since an entire truck must be painted from top to bottom in two days. The faster he paints, he said, the faster he is paid—about ten thousand rupees (90 U.S. dollars) per truck.

Despite his skillful craft, Imran does not dwell on the beauty of his work. His own nonchalant attitude reflects an unfortunate reality: Until recently, truck art was not widely recognized.

"While there existed a time when nobody knew about truck art, the art form has now come to be representative of Pakistan in both the local and international community," Nawab told me.

She said that her passion for truck art stems from her interest in how Pakistani art has spread to merchandise, like shoes and furniture. In Nawab's view, truck art, which is cheaply attainable and created by informally skilled workers, overshadows the art of famous Muslim artisans such as Allax Bux and Sadequain.

In her book, Nawab explores the history of truck art. Writing about the truck art phenomenon proved difficult because it has not evolved in a linear manner, nor has it historically been well-documented. During the 16th and 17th century, Mughal princes acted as strong patrons of the arts and encouraged artisans to produce intricate work for their kingdoms. When the Mughal Empire was replaced by British rule, princely states remained intact. Artisans continued their crafts in Hyderabad and Deccan, where former kings continued to have

"You know the way you go to school?" he said.
"This is school for us."



their homes colored with pictures of blooming flowers and soaring birds.

Durriya Kazi, a sculptor and researcher of truck art, told Nawab that after the 1947 partition, families migrated to Pakistan. One was the family of Haji Hussain Saab, a pioneer of truck art. The migration of skilled artisans into Pakistan coincided with a "boom in the transportation industry," she said. With the princely states now gone, artisans needed employment. They chose to decorate the identical, bland Bedford trucks being imported with increasing frequency into Pakistan.

Nawab noted that for the truck owners, art is like a "marketing technique." In order to sell their vehicle, the owners must make their trucks look more glamorous than their competitors'. People assume that if so much effort is put into maintaining a truck, it must be worth something.

In the past, truck art has also been a propaganda tool. In 1965, when India and Pakistan were at war over the disputed territory of Kashmir, trucks bore nationalistic and militaristic slogans. For example, one read, *"'Pak fauj Zindabad!"* (Long live the Pakistani army!)

Over time, however, trucks have come to represent the local preferences of the truck drivers. A famous portrait of a local Sindhi singer, Jalal Chandi, is a common feature on many trucks. Nawab noted that other references to popular culture often appear on buses.

Zafarullah Zehri, a senator from Balochistan—one of Pakistan's four provinces—is painted on the back of one truck. His beard is twirled at the edges, and his eyes are painted in a warm hazel. Nawab said that the paintings, which are specific to different provinces, function as a sort of passport for the truck drivers. Balochistan, for example, is a province that has a history of political tensions with the national government of Pakistan and, more specifically, with the Pakistani army. If a driver has the painting of a Balochistan-supporting politician on his truck, Nawab said, he is less likely to be stalled at security checks in Balochistan.



On her tour through Punjab, Balochistan, Khyber Pakhtunkhwa, and Sindh, Nawab found that artisans in different provinces had unique skill sets. In Peshawar, the capital of Khyber Pakhtunkhwa, artisans excelled in mirror work. In Rawalpindi, they crafted decorations with *chamak patti.* Karachi represented the confluence of all these different specialties. Though Pakistan has serious regional divisions, "borders are incredibly porous in the truck world," Nawab said.

Karachi is a city of bearded faces, women in flowing *abaya*, teenage girls wearing t-shirts, old couples in traditional *shalwar kameez,* all turning to see the kaleidoscope of colors that drives past them in the form of a painted truck. In the painting of a winking eye, you see the dreams of beautiful landscapes of romantics. In the tangled chains, you see the anxiety of businessmen. In the slogans, you see the ambitions of the public. And in the paintings of Lollywood actresses, you see the desire for ecstasy and entertainment. In the Sufi folklore, you see the need for protection and the fear of death. In the birds, you see the desire for peace.

Looking at the truck art, you are cast full force into the dizzying vibrancy of Karachi.



PAST PRESIDENTIAL PETS, CLOCKWISE FROM TOP LEFT: SOCKS (CLINTON), BARNEY (W. BUSH), BUDDY (CLINTON), INDIA (W. BUSH), BO AND SUNNY (OBAMA), REX (REAGAN)

Fire and Furry: America's Petless President

BY **JACK KELLY**

DONALD TRUMP IS the oldest president in history. He has the greatest net worth and the largest number of ex-wives, the least prior political experience, and the lowest recorded approval rating upon entering office of any Commander-in-Chief. He is also the first president in 150 years without a pet.

Among all these extremes, the last might seem ancillary. But it's a narrative the press can't seem to resist: Since the presidential election, outlets from *CNN* to the **New York Times** have run stories on Trump's petlessness. It's not hard to see why. The break with presidential tradition at the animal level offers a relatable and furry heuristic for the innumerable differences between the current administration and preceding ones. Add in the fact that the last petless president—Andrew Johnson—was impeached, and the story seems irresistible.

Not only does Trump not own a pet, he also seems to have a vendetta against those who do. *The Atlantic* recently published a White House advisor's claim that Trump called the Pence family "low class" for bringing its pets to the Naval Observatory residence, where the vice president lives. Unlike the Trumps, the Pence family is fully capitalizing on a pet's ability to humanize politicians; their bunny Marlon Bundo (are the Pences unaware of the actor's bisexuality?) has an Instagram and a soon-to-be-released book.

Trump has spoken about animals, but not through a ghost writer

and a book deal. Despite the canine lacuna in Trump's White House, pets—namely dogs, the most frequent White House animal—play an outsized role in his speech. After Michael Wolff's *Fire and Fury* became the Washington buzz, Trump tweeted, "Michael Wolff is a total loser who made up stories in order to sell this really boring and untruthful book. He used Sloppy Steve Bannon, who cried when he got fired and begged for his job. Now Sloppy Steve has been dumped like a dog by almost everyone. Too bad!"

While ostracized from the White House and *Breitbart*, perhaps Bannon can take solace in knowing he's in good company as a victim of this locution. As *Newsweek* noted in October 2017, Trump used the exact phrase "fired like a dog" in reference to David Gregory's canning from *Meet the Press*, Glenn Beck's exit from *Fox News*, and Rick Tyler's forced resignation as Ted Cruz' Director of Communications (this last tweet used a mixed-mammal metaphor: "[Cruz] used him as a scapegoat – fired like a dog!") Marco Rubio was "sweating like a dog" (panting?) at a debate. And as *Newsweek* also noted, Sally Yates, James Clapper, and Mitt Romney all "choke[d] like dogs," while George Pataki, John Sununu, and Bob Corker "couldn't get elected dog catcher" in their respective states.

You could fold into the mix of strange dog analogies the infamous line from the *Access Hollywood* video of Trump and Billy Bush. Although "I grabbed her by the pussy" was the most widely publicized quote of the video, "I moved on her like a bitch" was another one of the leaked soundbites that threatened Trump's electoral chances.

But what exactly is he saying? Emily Nussbaum, TV Critic for *The New Yorker*, tweeted in December 2017, "I realize this is the world's smallest issue, but I still don't understand what 'I moved on her like a bitch' means."

If "bitch" carries a double whammy—its sexist connotations and Trump's apparent disdain for dogs in general—why is he comparing himself to one? Is it just a slip-up breeding grammatical ambiguity? Or something in between—a strange but perhaps subconscious line that might reveal both Trump's peculiar psychology around pets and the broader illogic of his presidency?

We might find answers in Trump's pre-political life. In *Raising Trump*, released last October, Ivana Trump, the president's first wife, highlights dogs as a central theme, an animal bedrock among all the human melodrama.

"I can't imagine a childhood without a pet of some kind. From animals, people get a pure, unconditional love," she notes in an early chapter. In young adulthood, this love took the form of a poodle named Chappy.

Ivana Trump owned Chappy when she was still known as Ivana Zelníčková, an aspiring model and businesswoman fresh out of communist Czechoslovakia. She later met Donald Trump, then a real-estate developer under the tutelage of Roy Cohn. The book paints their falling in love as rapid, natural, and without obstacles—except for one.

"Donald was not a dog fan," Ivana Trump notes, adding that Chappy had a strong "dislike of Donald," too. These interests collided, and she sided with the dog: "When I told [Donald] I was bringing Chappy with me to New York, he said no. 'It's me and Chappy or no one!' I insisted, and that was that."

Granted, *Raising Trump* is full of these kinds of my-way-or-the-highway details. But it seems to be no accident that Ivana Trump's chapter about pets directly precedes the chapter about her husband's affair with Marla Maples. As Ivana Trump describes her ensuing divorce, it's easy to sense a juxtaposition of the highly conditional love she shares with her husband and the unconditional affection she reserves for her pets and children. Trump, his ex-wife seems to argue, tolerates pets with the same fleeting commitment usually reserved for his wives.

To the extent that pets have humanized presidents as persons, they have also protected their owners as politicians. When Franklin Delano Roosevelt faced re-election for a fourth term, for example, Republican opponents claimed he'd sent a Naval Destroyer to the Aleutian Islands merely to return his dog, Fala, to Washington. His "Fala Speech," delivered to a DC Labor Union and broadcast over radio, codified the limits of political warfare in animal terms. "These Republican leaders have not been content with

In Trump's Words

"fired like a dog" (David Gregory, Glenn Beck, and Rick Tyler)
"sweating like a dog" (Marco Rubio)
"choke[d] like dogs" (Sally Yates, James Clapper, and Mitt Romney)
"couldn't get elected dog catcher" (George Pataki, John Sununu, and Bob Corker)

attacks on me, or my wife, or on my sons," he began. "No, not content with that, they now include my little dog, Fala. Well, of course, I don't resent attacks...but Fala does resent them."

It was a comedic speech, which had the audience "laughing and cheering and calling for more," according to Doris Kearns Goodwin in her biography of the Roosevelts, *No Ordinary Time*. But the Fala speech also encapsulated a deep truth about the role of pets in the White House: Dogs are depoliticized symbols, too domestic and innocent for the vicissitudes of partisanry. But this status is what imbues the pet with its political purchase. The four-legged inhabitants of the White House serve as political tools by virtue of their anti-politics, a *homo sacer* that gains its status from not being human at all.

In 1952, Richard Nixon was embroiled in controversy over illicit campaign funding when he served as Eisenhower's running mate in the presidential election. At the time, he delivered his "Checkers speech," saying, "there is one thing that I did get as a gift that I'm not going to give back." He was speaking of Checkers, the Cocker Spaniel he'd recently given his daughters.

More than fifty years later, in 2008, as opposition to the Iraq War increased, George W. Bush quipped, "I will not withdraw even if Laura and Barney," his Scottish Terrier, "are the only ones supporting me." His mother, Barbara, meanwhile, filled the role that Karen Pence is now taking, writing a pseudo-autobiography for her and H.W.'s English Springer, Millie. *Millie's Book: As Dictated to Barbara Bush* rose to #1 on the *New York Times* Best Seller list in 1990.

Hillary Clinton was less successful in her turn as First-Pet ghost author. She and Bill adopted a dog, Buddy, in 1997, and already had a cat named Socks. Unfortunately, the interspecies dynamic was fraught, and revelations of Socks and Buddy's relationship woes arose at the same time as the reveal of the President and First Lady's. As the Lewinsky affair unfolded, many speculated that the pets served as political cover. A few weeks before Clinton's impeachment hearing began, Hillary Clinton released *Dear Socks, Dear Buddy: Kids' Letters to the First Pets*, which was perhaps an epistolary attempt to portray first-familial unity. Of the roughly half a million copies printed for the first release, only 350,000 sold.

Most of all, there appears to be a unique bifurcation in the Trump presidency between the political and the private. His personal life pre-presidency has been more visible than almost any Commander-in-Chief's, but he worked in the White House alone for six months before Melania and Barron left New York to join him. This December, the White House released its Christmas card, featuring the text "Merry Christmas and a Happy New Year" above embossed golden signatures from Donald, Melania, and Barron Trump next to a presidential seal. The cold simplicity is in stark contrast to Obama's message a year prior—"As we gather around this season, may the warmth and joy of the holidays fill your home," framed by a pop-out model of the White House above and the signature of his family, along with two dog footprints for Sunny and Bo.

Perhaps Trump's petless White House intentionally reflects the politics of a profit-maximizing CEO draining the swamp of such elitist frivolities. Or it might reflect a machismo-driven, maverick POTUS who avoids shrouding his tenure in the kind of domestic warmth that past presidents have cultivated through the role of the first lady, children, and pets. Or Trump could just hate pets, perhaps irrationally, as evidenced in his strange use of canine analogies, and in Ivana Trump's memoir.

The Trump presidency, with its blurry division of personal and political motives gives a Janus-faced nature to the question of intentionality. Did Trump tap into a deep realm in the American psyche that wanted a politician defined by what politicians are not, with no baby kissing, pet owning, or bill passing? Is he an unstable megalomaniac who got lucky in a close election, and whose unpredictable personality now dominates? The pet problem does not offer us answers to these questions, but it shows the ways in which Trump's presidency has transformed the questions we ask.

Trump Administration critics might say: "Who cares about the president's dog?" Though the focus on Trump's lack of pets differentiates him from prior presidents, it is potentially distracting from the realities of his actions. And so ironically, the lack of a pet in Trump's White House might serve the same function as the presence of a pet did for past presidents. For those who feel threatened by Trump's actions, the media obsession with the paucity of paws in the new administration may feel painfully like the tail wagging the dog.

Donald was not a dog fan.

—Ivana Trump

STARDOM FOR SALE

BY LILY MOORE-EISSENBERG

AT TALENT CONVENTIONS FOR KIDS, FAMILIES BUY IN AND LOSE OUT

STARDOM FOR SALE

ON DECEMBER 23, 2016, Moumita Clifton, a 34-year-old who splits her time between California and Japan, where her husband is deployed in the Navy, was at home in Los Angeles when she received an ecstatic email.

"CONGRATULATIONS!!!"

the message began, in bold and italics.

"YOU MADE THE CALLBACK TO LA, THE ENTERTAINMENT CAPITAL OF THE WORLD!"

Weeks before, Clifton, who is working toward a PhD in Geographic Information Systems and Remote Sensing, decided to try her six-month-old daughter's luck in the talent circuit. When an advertisement promoting a showcase called Next—short for Next Star Productions—popped up in her Facebook News Feed, Clifton opted to make the trip to San Diego for the first round of auditions, held in a hotel.

In retrospect, she regrets the choice. The venue for the open-call auditions was "not high-end," which "should have been a red flag," she said. Kids of all ages and their parents filled a large room, where the showcase's representatives gave what Clifton described as "literally a sales pitch."

"They make it sound really good," Clifton said. "Kids who are teenagers or like ten years old, they get really excited, especially when they [the representatives] name kids from Disney and Nickelodeon."

At showcases like Next, aspiring child models and actors pay to audition for talent agents, hoping to "be discovered." Usually, participants have advanced through several rounds of auditions or have taken classes at a feeder school. All have paid a substantial sum to be there.

Clifton purchased professional photos, coordinated by Next, so that her daughter could attend the upcoming showcase in San Diego. (According to Clifton, the photographer was actually a teenager who later participated in the Los Angeles showcase.) About two weeks later, after the San Diego showcase, the email announcing her daughter's invitation to the national convention arrived in her inbox. With each passing round, Clifton found herself emptying her pockets: first for the photos (250 dollars, the cheapest option), and later to pay upfront fees for the showcase in Los Angeles (1,070 dollars, according to an email correspondence between Clifton and Denise Johnson, who is the CEO and Vice President of Next Star Productions), plus the costs of travel, accommodation, and food.

But in early December of 2016, convenience factored into Clifton's calculations. "No big deal," Clifton remembers thinking to herself at first. After all, San Diego, where the open-call auditions would take place, wasn't far from her home in Los Angeles. "Just go," she thought.

"I should have known it was a sham at the time," Clifton told me.

Families across the U.S. have been similarly seduced. The "Hollywood dream"—a cinematic offshoot of the American one, coined by Richard Verrier of *the Los Angeles Times*—sparkles in the imaginations of children everywhere. And the industry has risen to meet the demand. Hanging on the lower rungs of the ladder to stardom, many talent conventions rely on a foot-in-the-door money-making strategy which, in dealings with starry-eyed children and eager parents, has proven lucrative. Showcases draw children and families, like Clifton's, from around the country by starting locally, with peppy advertisements on local radio channels, open-call auditions, and upfront fees that increase and accumulate. By branding themselves as "elite" and requiring training (for a fee), many showcases manufacture the appearance of selectivity, feeding false hope that can lead to bankruptcy for families that continue to pay beyond their means.

...SPARKLES IN THE IMAGINATIONS OF CHILDREN EVERYWH

OF SALE F

THE "HOLLYWOOD DREAM," A CINEMATIC OFFSHOOT OF THE AMERICAN ONE,

Among conventions, reputations vary. Though there is no nationwide tally of talent showcases for kids, a few giants, like the International Modeling and Talent Association (IMTA) and the International Performing Arts Showcase (IPAS), dominate the terrain. Unlike Next showcases, these are big-budget, glitzy productions: Kids and teens with professionally-done makeup and clothes strut down gleaming stages, backlit by bright lights. But on Ripoff Report, a website "for consumers, by consumers" where users can report scams and fraud, 47 complaints have been filed about IMTA. They cover 19 states, representing both coasts, the Midwest, the Southwest, and the Deep South. And in California, a class action lawsuit is underway against IPAS and a major feeder school, the Barbizon School of San Francisco.

By comparison, Next Star Productions looks reputable, if low-budget. In one video, live-streamed from a Next convention in Las Vegas, children with numbered bibs walk between rows of chairs in a beige-paneled hotel conference room, smiling and turning in circles for the small audience. Next showcases are relatively small operations: 85 to 125 performers attend each of the four national conventions, wrote CEO Denise Johnson in an email correspondence with me. Rosters supported the statement. As the businesswoman pointed out, larger showcases host several hundreds of performers.

"I suggest doing a story on the talent showcases that have over 700 performers in their events that charge up to $12,000 [per] showcase," Johnson wrote in an email to me. "That's a story!"

In California, home of the American entertainment industry, advance-fee talent representation is illegal, under the Krekorian Talent Scam Prevention Act of 2010. (An advance fee is money paid to an agent before goods or services have been provided.) BizParentz Foundation, an organization that provides education and advocacy services to families in the entertainment industry, warns on its website that "the first rule of showbiz is 'never pay upfront fees for representation.'"

But showcases have found ways to bend the rules. When I asked how much a performer must pay to attend a showcase, Johnson wrote: "We hold a Regional Showcase and a National Showcase...a performers [sic] experience will determine if there is a cost or no cost at all." Johnson used a sports analogy to justify the fees that the organization charges for required training, citing football, volleyball, and cheerleading. Without the training, "inexperienced" performers cannot attend the showcase. To qualify as "experienced," a performer must have prior professional training and a "built resume," according to Johnson.

"They will pay a fee to train, to perform well," Johnson wrote. "The same goes for our industry or any industry. There is a [sic] investment involved. All actors and models have to train to **perform at their Top Level** with **Confidence**!"

But, according to email records from December of 2016, Next charges registration fees per person (395 dollars for Clifton's daughter, 175 dollars each for Clifton and her husband) and per category (325 dollars each; Clifton selected "Modeling"), regardless of experience. These fees were listed in an email that Clifton sent to Johnson directly, asking whether her calculation of the total cost was correct. It was, Johnson confirmed via email.

IMTA—a New York City-based association that, according to its website, hosts the largest international talent convention—defends itself online in language similar to Johnson's. In answer to a "frequently asked question" about the legitimacy of its showcase, IMTA suggests that some discontented attendees have "chose[n] to see [associated costs] as a ripoff rather than an investment."

But when it comes to the payoff, organizers avoid making concrete promises. In a statement published by *Dateline NBC*, for example, IMTA highlighted success stories but also emphasized the benefits of attending for kids who never become stars. "Like many other endeavors, most Contestants who have worked hard and attended their training sessions have their efforts rewarded," claimed IMTA in the statement. "All participants [gain] valuable life lessons and an unforgettable experience."

The experience wasn't worth the price for Valerie Wright, a 49-year-old single mother living in Memphis, Tennessee, who estimates that the total cost of attending two conventions with her son exceeded 10,000 dollars. A survivor of lupus, Wright is unable to work; she supports herself and her three children on Social Security payments. In 2014, she and her son, who was nine at the time,



traveled to Orlando, Florida for their first convention, which was organized by a company called Premiere.

"It seemed like [the other families] were all bubbly at the beginning of the week," she said. "We were all one big family." By the end, though, the mood had darkened.

"I saw kids and parents crying, getting mad, and leaving, storming out, and I'm thinking, 'I'm winning,'" Wright said.

In 2016, Wright and her son attended a convention organized by the Donna Groff Agency, which is based in Memphis. Her son was supposed to go the year before, but after paying roughly 7,000 dollars for the 2015 convention, Wright could not afford the 700-dollar photoshoot. The payment deadline for the shoot passed, and owner and director Donna Groff said that Wright and her son would have to wait until the 2016 convention. The next year, Wright paid a transfer fee (about 275 dollars, she said), plus the fee for a photoshoot, which had increased from 2015. Only pictures taken by the hired photographer would be accepted.

"I was spending bill money, food money, trying to pursue this dream for my kid," Wright told me over the phone in her slight Southern accent. "Those callbacks didn't mean nothing," she said.

But callbacks are a key part of industry advertising. The number of children called back is the metric of success cited by many showcases. In its *NBC* statement, IMTA estimated that 80 percent of participants receive callbacks. On its website, Premiere advertises that its "Industry Professionals call back over 60 percent of the performers in attendance." (Neither Premiere nor IPAS replied to requests for comment. IMTA responded to an introductory email, but did not reply to follow-up inquiries.)

As Wright noted, though, callbacks mean little for families not living in New York City or Los Angeles. ("The real answer," a casting director named Katie Taylor told me, "is there really isn't anything you can do when you live in Saskatchewan.") Wright's son scored nine callbacks at Premiere's showcase. Each time, he heard the same thing: He and his family would have to move. "There's nothing for you in Tennessee," the scouts told him, according to his mother. But relocating was a financial impossibility. Wright and her son left the convention with lighter pockets and little gained.

Even for children living in Hollywood hubs, callbacks do not always lead to jobs. A friend Clifton met at the San Diego auditions named Melanie Ruiz, who could not be reached for this article, thought her son had hit on success, Clifton said. According to Clifton's retelling, scouts had indicated they wanted to sign Ruiz's son, only to reject him two weeks later because they had another client who looked similar. It wouldn't be ethical to represent two clients competing for the same gigs, they said.

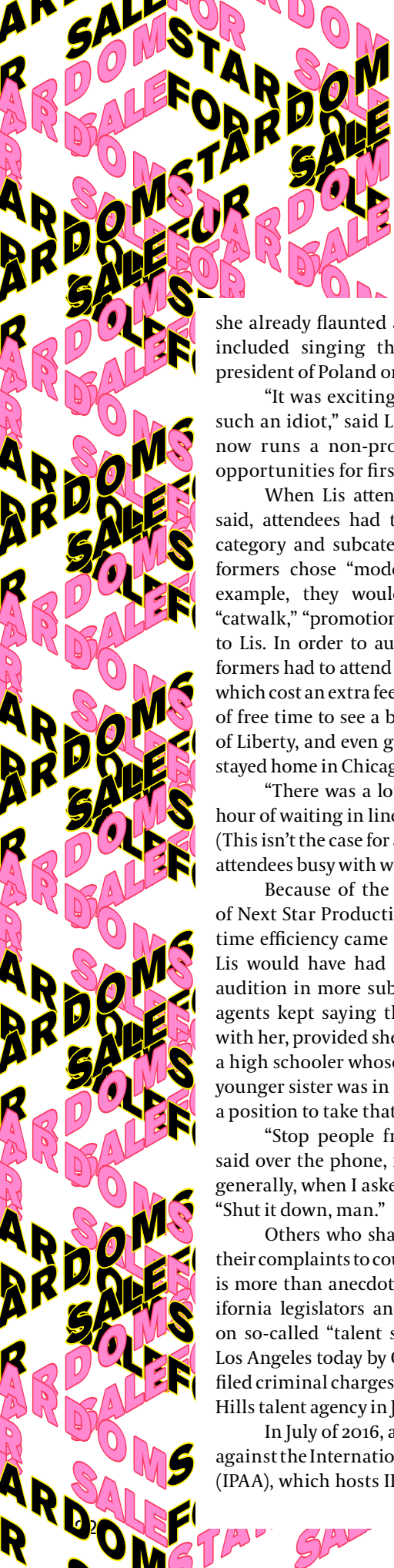
"The rejection was done in private," Clifton told me, relating the story she had heard from her friend. But in public, the scouts had "made a big show out of picking him up," as performers and parents looked on. (Taylor, the casting director, confirmed the public pick-up, private drop tactic in a phone interview.)

Still, to some parents, a shot at fame for their children—even a long-shot—is close to priceless. But when the several thousand dollars in fees, travel, food, and accommodation come to naught, parents and children alike head home defeated and deceived.

Clifton described the way Next Star Productions runs its showcase as "sketchy"—a charitable criticism, compared to the language used by past attendees of other showcases. ("Sham," "scam," "wham-bam-thank-you-ma'am," and "money-suck" were a few choice descriptors used in interviews with parents, a talent agent, and a former participant.) Unlike Clifton and her daughter, most showcase attendees come from out of state, sometimes traveling thousands of miles and paying thousands of dollars only to be told, in auditions, to move to Los Angeles. But kids with big dreams (and, in some cases, "momagers" with bigger ones), keep clamoring to attend.

Kasia Lis, a 27-year-old who took classes at Barbizon, a major feeder school for showcases, and who attended the IMTA showcase in Los Angeles ten years ago, called the event a "cattle call." The Chicagoan flew to California with high hopes. At 17,

"ALL ACTORS AND MODELS HAVE TO TRAIN TO PERFORM AT THEIR TOP LEVEL WITH CONFIDENCE!"



she already flaunted an impressive resume, which included singing the national anthem for the president of Poland on one of his visits to the U.S.

"It was exciting, and it was new…God, I was such an idiot," said Lis of the IMTA showcase. She now runs a non-profit that creates scholarship opportunities for first-generation Americans.

When Lis attended the IMTA showcase, she said, attendees had to pay an extra fee for each category and subcategory of auditions. After performers chose "modeling" as their category, for example, they would select subcategories, like "catwalk," "promotional," and "lifestyle," according to Lis. In order to audition in a subcategory, performers had to attend the corresponding workshop, which cost an extra fee. Lis remembers having plenty of free time to see a baseball game, visit the Statue of Liberty, and even go to a strip club. (Her parents stayed home in Chicago because of travel costs.)

"There was a lot of downtime," she said. "An hour of waiting in line, thirty seconds in the room." (This isn't the case for all showcases; some keep their attendees busy with workshops and presentations.)

Because of the workshop rule—reminiscent of Next Star Productions' required training—even time efficiency came at a price. To fill up her days, Lis would have had to pay for more training to audition in more subcategories. According to Lis, agents kept saying that they would love to work with her, provided she moved to Los Angeles. But as a high schooler whose parents had jobs and whose younger sister was in middle school, she was not in a position to take that risk.

"Stop people from attending this shit," Lis said over the phone, referring to talent showcases generally, when I asked if she had anything to add. "Shut it down, man."

Others who share Lis's sentiment have taken their complaints to court. The accumulated evidence is more than anecdotal: Over the past decade, California legislators and courts have cracked down on so-called "talent scams," a trend continued in Los Angeles today by City Attorney Mike Feuer, who filed criminal charges against an unlicensed Beverly Hills talent agency in January.

In July of 2016, a class action lawsuit was filed against the International Performing Arts Academy (IPAA), which hosts IPAS, and the Barbizon School of San Francisco on behalf of California mother Angelica Cosio and "others similarly situated." Also listed as defendants are Lion Management Group, which manages IPAS, and members of the Lionetti family, who run Lion Management and the Barbizon School of San Francisco.

According to the complaint, the Barbizon School of San Francisco used unlawful advertising to mislead children and parents, soliciting advance fees and enticing them to attend IPAS. Further, the lawsuit accuses the school of selecting participants based on ability and willingness to pay rather than perceived merit, while "creat[ing] an impression of exclusivity." Litigation, which began in April of 2016, is ongoing, and the defense denies any wrongdoing.

The lead plaintiff filed these complaints on the grounds that the defendants violated sections of California labor code that prohibit advance-fee talent representation services. Advertising or referring others to such services is illegal under the code. Legislative reports from April 2009, when the bill was under committee consideration, show the reasoning behind the legislation.

"With the unprecedented popularity of 'American Idol' and other reality television programming, the false promise of instant stardom has increasingly become a fertile ground for talent peddlers to scam the public, victimizing children and young adults in particular," wrote the bill's author, Los Angeles City Councilman Paul Krekorian, who was a state assemblyman at the time. He characterizes the audition process as "bait and switch." The California District Attorneys Association, the Los Angeles City Attorney's Office, and the Screen Actors Guild supported the legislation.

In 2009, about 1,000 complaints and 143,000 inquiries were filed in southern California that are "responsive" to the case against the Barbizon School of San Francisco, according to statistics from the Better Business Bureau of the Southland. ("Responsive" means the complaints are somehow related to the lawsuit, directly or tangentially; some might have involved other branches of Barbizon or a different set of grievances than those filed by Cosio.) As of October 17, 2016, the Federal Trade Commission had received 275 complaints about Barbizon.

The deception extended to solicitation of

client feedback for court-related purposes, *Law360* reported. Barbizon conducted interviews without informing clients that their feedback would be filed in court as sworn declarations and possibly used against their interests.

Despite legislation and lawsuits, showcases continue to sell their services. Brochures, advertisements, and scouts milk "success stories" to attract talent, name-dropping popular channels, shows, agencies, and celebrities. Actors who have disputed claims of affiliation with IPAA, for example, include Halle Berry, Jennifer Garner, and Chris Hemsworth, according to the online magazine *Deadline Hollywood*. Wording is key: Over email, one Barbizon manager warned scouts against telling potential clients that the school had worked with Taylor Lautner, the teen heartthrob best known for playing the pining werewolf in *Twilight*; instead, they should say the school had worked with his manager, which was technically true.

Katie Taylor, a preschool teacher-turned-casting director from Los Angeles, told me she has seen people "get sucked in" time and time again.

"These agents go because they get wined and dined," she said, her voice rising. "It's like a vacay where they get treated like a celebrity."

The reason showcases are so appealing, Taylor told me, is that they look like shortcuts. "All you have to do is pay," she said. But Taylor, who founded her own casting agency, Taylor Casting, in 2000, knows from experience that shortcuts rarely win aspiring actors and models top jobs.

"It's only a smart and lucrative opportunity for children when you treat it like soccer," Taylor said. In her view, success requires relocating to Los Angeles and going to auditions several times a week. Even then, agents are often searching for specific looks, which cannot be taught or bought. "That mixed Asian little girl with the green eyes!" Taylor trilled, imitating an excited talent scout. "They're like, 'Oh my gosh, you're the unicorn child!'"

For Clifton, the irony remains that while at the showcase, she was able to connect with agents who were not present by contacting them online, without Next's help.

"The very next day, I got an email back from all the big ones," she said. "It did not cost me a dollar."

Now, Clifton manages her daughter's career herself and works with modeling agencies directly. Zuri Model and Talent, a reputable talent agency based in New York City, represents Clifton's daughter, who is now two years old and has 12,600 Instagram followers. (Her mother manages her account.)

"It was so easy. Literally, I just emailed them," Clifton said of pursuing representation on her own, as opposed to trying to get her daughter "discovered" at a showcase. "If anyone is asking for money upfront, they are a scam."

But demystifying the Hollywood dream is not so easy. Wright, Clifton, Lis, and Taylor all called for better education.

"Study before you leap," Wright said. Now that she is managing her son's acting career, he has played small roles in films and theater productions, and has featured in commercials. The money he makes is their household's only source of income besides Social Security.

When asked what could be done to prevent talent scams, Taylor said she imagined "cheap or free" information sessions that "basically lay it out"—that tell families, "This is how you do it for real."

"It's such a predatory business in every way," Taylor said. Informing parents is one thing; actually convincing them to stay away from showcases before they have been scammed is another.

In the industry, the young actors and models competing for callbacks at showcases are collectively called "the talent." The word is everywhere, modifying "agent," "convention," and "scout," and appearing in the names of the biggest agencies. The word may be the most distinctive feature of industry advertising, and its ubiquity sends an important, if subliminal, message: You have talent.

The message plays on unswerving parental confidence—whether warranted or not. In a Facebook comment thread about talent conventions, nearly thirty agents, parents, and former participants vented and issued warnings. Valerie Wright, resentful but undiscouraged, wrote the following:

"Unfortunately, I got caught up twice with my son. But never again. He is a talented fashion runway, print, and commercial model and an actor. His gift will make room for him."

Ancient Islands

Newest Country?

New Caledonia Prepares to Vote on Independence





BY **RAHUL NAGVEKAR**

TOP: THE MOUNTAIN UPLANDS OF NEW CALEDONIA'S LARGEST ISLAND
BOTTOM: A PRO-INDEPENDENCE PROTESTOR WAVES A SEPARATIST FLAG

AS THE PACIFIC SUN rises, shades of orange bathe an island port featuring both palm and pine trees. A cathedral that might not look out of place in Latin America stands a mere fifteen-minute drive from the towering curved pavilions of an indigenous cultural center.

Inland, pale grey ground-dwelling birds with brilliant crests are performing distinctive morning duets reminiscent of a dog's bark. These birds, known as kagus, are found in the wild only on this island. Locals call them "ghosts of the forest."

Far from the city, ranchers on horseback drive cattle over the rolling scrubland of the bush. In a few weeks' time, one of the world's oldest species of flowering plants will be in bloom in the uplands, just as it has been since the age of dinosaurs. Nickel ore is extracted from the earth at a handful of sprawling pits scattered across the island, while haze rises from a smelter on the port's western shore.

This is New Caledonia.

About a thousand miles east of Australia, the archipelago has been home to endemic flora and fauna for tens of millions of years, inhabited by humans for over three millennia, and part of France since 1853. And following a referendum to be held later this year, it might just become the world's newest independent country.

But maybe not so fast.

The exact date of the referendum, as well as the wording of the ballot question, is still to be decided. Only last November did pro- and anti-independence parties agree on who would be allowed to vote.

"People are confused, and things are in flux," said Walter Zweifel, a journalist who covers New Caledonia for Radio New Zealand, in an interview with *The Politic*.

Some say a vote for independence would mark the end of a long-overdue decolonization process. Others insist it would begin a period of profound uncertainty.

But what is certain is that a referendum will take place by November. The vote is mandated by the archipelago's governing charter, the Nouméa Accord, which was itself approved by referendum in 1998. Named after New Caledonia's capital and main city, the Accord granted the islands a unique autonomous status within France and set out a roadmap for the gradual transfer of powers away from Paris.

Twenty years later, New Caledonia's 270,000 inhabitants live in relative harmony. Most are either Kanaks, the islands' native Melanesian people, or Europeans, who began arriving after France established a penal colony on the largest island in the mid-19th century.

But few New Caledonians of any ethnic group have fond memories of the time before the Nouméa Accord.

During the first few decades of colonial rule, disease, wars, and coerced indentured servitude decimated the native population.

"When the French came in, they just ran the place, and the locals were almost—not slaves, but there were restrictions on where the Kanaks could move," Zweifel said.

Roch Wamytan signed the Nouméa Accord in 1998 as the then-leader of the major pro-independence force, the Kanak and Socialist National Liberation Front (FLNKS). When he spoke with *The Politic* about the Kanak people's history, he did not mince words.

"We lived under triumphant colonialism," Wamytan said. "The Kanak people were under the thumb of the French government."

That began to change, he explained, with the global wave of decolonization that followed World War II. Kanaks gained French citizenship and voting rights. Even the word "Kanak" (then spelled "Canaque"), previously a derogatory term for Melanesians, became a point of pride among New Caledonia's native inhabitants.

Despite this progress, New Caledonia remained far from independent well into the 1980s, unlike nearby sovereign states like Vanuatu and Fiji. Frustrated with the slow pace of change and what it viewed as French attempts to sabotage moves toward autonomy, the FLNKS took up arms. The resulting multi-year insurgency included a hostage crisis in a cave that

saw 19 separatist militants and two French gendarmes killed.

Denise Fisher, who served as Australian Consul-General in Nouméa between 2001 and 2004 and is now a fellow at the Australian National University, explained in an email to *The Politic* that both sides wish to hold this year's referendum ahead of the November deadline.

Many on the islands remember the separatist boycott of local elections in November 1984, complete with the destruction of ballot boxes, as the beginning of the violence.

"The fact that this is considered relevant highlights the awareness by all of the risks that the poll process may reignite deep sensitivities," Fisher wrote.

New Caledonia has held an independence referendum before—in 1987, amidst the insurgency. But France and the FLNKS failed to agree on the eligible electorate, and most Kanaks boycotted the vote. The 98 percent result in favor of staying with France did little to resolve the ongoing conflict.

The violence did subside after separatists and loyalists signed a collection of agreements in Paris the following year. But with the Nouméa Accord now allowing up to three referendums on independence between 2018 and 2022 and calling for additional talks if each produces a pro-France result, many are concerned that old tensions could boil over.

"We really don't want a war again," Nouméa-based freelance journalist Coralie Cochin told *The Politic* in an interview.

Zweifel argued that the situation today is meaningfully different from the 1980s.

"The simple polarization doesn't work," he said. "You can find Kanaks who are for remaining with France, Kanaks who are against staying with France, just as you find [European] settlers there who would quite like to create some form of independent country of New Caledonia."

The legacy of a darker past still lingers.

"Inequality—above all ethnic inequality—is the most important issue that divides the people," wrote Mathias Chauchat, a professor of public law at the University of New Caledonia, in an email to *The Politic*. Kanaks are still, on average, significantly less wealthy than their European counterparts and more likely to not finish school or to be unemployed.

"Eighty-five percent of the incarcerated population is Kanak youth," separatist leader Wamytan said. (Kanaks make up about 40 percent of New Caledonia's population.) "If we were independent, we would not have witnessed this rise in criminality. We would have put in place reforms taking into account the social and cultural context."



A PRO-FRANCE PROTESTOR TAKES PART IN A DEMONSTRATION

Pastor and pro-independence activist Bilo Railati told *The Politic* in an interview, "We fight against an unequal system and especially against marginalization of the Kanak people."

Philippe Blaise, an anti-independence deputy in New Caledonia's Congress, sees that fight differently. "The [separatist] parties have a project of society that is based on ethnicity," he said in an interview with *The Politic*. "They want to give Kanaks specific rights according to their customary status."

As Blaise explained, the largest faction within the FLNKS has proposed expanding the powers of the Customary Senate, a New Caledonia-wide assembly representing traditional Kanak chiefs.

Not all Kanaks support such a change, but Blaise (who is white) is adamantly opposed.

"I was born in New Caledonia," he said. "My family has been there for five generations. We consider this place our home."

Blaise explained, "Today, as French citizens, [Kanaks and non-Kanaks] have the same rights. We obey the same laws. We cannot build this country with discrimination—you can't solve the injustices of the past with injustices in the future."

Of course, the separatists would have to win the referendum first. A single public opinion poll, from last April, showed the anti-independence camp leading 54 percent to 24 percent. There are still several months to go and a large undecided bloc, but Chauchat was fairly certain in making a prediction.

"The FLNKS will be defeated," he wrote.

Fisher was more cautious.

"Many pro-France supporters say the result of a referendum is likely to be 60 percent in favor of staying with France and 40 percent for full sovereignty," she told *The Politic*. "In fact, indicators are few."

Asked to rate his side's chances of victory, Railati responded, "I am 100 percent confident that we [separatists] have the right cards to win this referendum."

While the separatists have lost each of New Caledonia's last four general elections, they might benefit from provisions in the Nouméa Accord that effectively restrict the referendum's voting pool to Kanaks and long-term residents.

Cochin, a relatively recent immigrant from Normandy who cannot take part herself, told *The Politic* she was surprised when separatist and loyalist leaders reached a compromise last November to add a few thousand voters to the electoral roll. The common fear, she explained, was of a repeat of the ill-fated experience of the boycotted 1987 referendum.

This time around, primary players on both sides appear ready to accept the result as legitimate. With campaigning underway, French President Emmanuel Macron has promised to visit, but he has already expressed his preference for an anti-independence victory.

"The French presence is necessary to guarantee peace and development," Macron told the newspaper *Les Nouvelles calédoniennes* just before his own election last May.

In her email, Fisher noted that New Caledonia's vast nickel reserves—possibly exceeding a quarter of the global total—have long made France reluctant to entertain steps toward self-determination.

"By the 1970s, French experts were descending upon the archipelago," she wrote, "and the French State tightened its control...openly bringing in French residents from the metropolitan and other overseas territories in a bid specifically to outnumber the local indigenous and pro-independence people."

Macron made the case that a New Caledonia within France could better address growing problems on the islands like youth crime and alcoholism, but few doubt that France has other interests in the referendum outcome.

"The fact the French aid didn't decrease during the period of transfer of powers was the most surprising," Chauchat wrote. "Why did France give so much money to the country, if France would leave soon? New Caledonia is more dependent on France today than it was in the close past."

Fisher explained that France spends over two billion dollars in New Caledonia annually, making significant investments in the archipelago's schools, hospitals, and transport.

"The question is, if you have independence, will France provide that money?" Zweifel asked.

Loyalists would rather not find out.

"We are sure that if France leaves New Caledonia, the level of material life will drop," Blaise said. A brochure prepared by his party highlights that New Caledonia enjoys better medical care, higher wages, and vastly higher rates of car ownership and internet connectivity than nearby independent states like Fiji, Vanuatu, and Papua New Guinea.

Perhaps with these advantages in mind, some independence advocates are now proposing a "partnership" with France. But others continue to seek a clean break from French rule, possibly under the "decolonized" name *Kanaky*.

Locally-mined nickel is part of the reason New Caledonians have a higher standard of living than most of their Pacific neighbors. Nonetheless, a number of mining projects have drawn opposition from Kanak groups, and concerns persist about impacts on the islands' forests, wetlands, and extensive coral reef system.

"Economically, New Caledonia has prospered with the construction of two giant state-of-the-art nickel processing plants," Fisher wrote. Now, however, a global supply glut is keeping nickel prices low, and the plants are unprofitable. Many workers have already been laid off, with thousands more jobs under threat.

This danger is not lost on pro-France campaigners.

"Can nickel income substitute for state transfers?" asks a page in the anti-independence brochure.

"Soaring prices in 2007 gave the illusion of a nickel bonanza," reads part of the reply. "It is not so!"

But even without the current downturn, many separatists agree that an independent New Caledonia should not support itself on nickel alone.

Discussing the environmental costs of mining, Railati said, "When we fight for Kanaks and for Kanaky [New Caledonia], it's not only for access to our nickel, but it's also important that we fight for an independent Kanaky that is able to create an economy that is more sustainable."

Short- or long-term, the nickel sector's woes are hardly the only worry occupying New Caledonians. Cochin mentioned inequality, education, and health problems like diabetes and obesity.

"People seem more concerned by those kind of issues than whether the country is becoming independent or not," Cochin said.

Almost everyone interviewed for this story also acknowledged the sense of apprehension on the islands ahead of the vote. But despite coming from opposite sides of the referendum question, both Blaise and Railati remained hopeful.

"The best legacy we have had over the thirty last years," Blaise said, "is the fact that we have built a culture of democracy, and what was a fight in the civil war has turned into a political fight."

The pro-independence Railati had a similar message.

"People have died for the Nouméa Accord," he reminded *The Politic*. "So today is really an epic moment, a beautiful time for us."

Come 2019, a referendum will have happened. When the kagus crow for the first time that year, they may do so in a country on a path to independence, or one likely to remain part of France for the foreseeable future. But it will still be a place at once ancient and modern, bucolic and industrial, part Oceania and part Europe. It will still be New Caledonia.

NATIONAL FOOD FIGHT

BY **SELENA CHO**



THE TRUMP ADMINISTRATION TAKES ON OBAMA-ERA SCHOOL NUTRITION REGULATIONS

"WHO WANTS A HEATED BAGEL?" a woman called out from behind the cafeteria counter. At a table in Washington Elementary School in West Haven, in 2007, nine-year-old Susie Beyl leaped up to receive the culinary masterpiece. The renowned heated bagel, which consisted of a microwaved bagel and cream cheese, was offered to students who did not want the pepperoni pizza, hot dogs, or spaghetti featured on the regular lunch line.

"I was a picky eater, so I didn't like much of it," Beyl '20, now a student at Yale, said in an interview with *The Politic* about her elementary school experience.

"I was just starting to toy with vegetarianism, and sometimes I found that I didn't have much food to eat," she said. "I was never really into the juices that were provided either, or the milks. I was a big water drinker, but at my elementary school, they never provided bottles of water unless you bought them."

Beyl lacked healthy options because Washington Elementary School followed outdated national school nutrition standards last revised in 1980. As a result, elementary schooler Beyl had no choice but to wait for the heated bagel and drink rusty-tasting fountain water.

But those standards changed during Beyl's middle school years. In 2010, under Barack Obama's presidency, Congress passed the first reform to school nutrition standards in 30 years: the Healthy, Hunger-Free Kids Act. In an interview with *The Politic*, Colin Schwartz, a senior nutrition policy associate at the Center for Science in the Public Interest, called the Act one of the "greatest achievements...to prevent childhood obesity."

Though the Trump administration has not repealed the landmark law, it has used every opportunity to push back at its aims. On May 1, 2017, the administration announced plans to relax Obama-era nutrition guidelines set by the Department of Agriculture. Trump's Secretary of Agriculture Sonny Perdue, who is leading the change, cited increased food waste and heightened complaints from students and school administrators as reasons for the revisions.

The Healthy, Hunger-Free Kids Act is a legacy of former First Lady Michelle Obama, who pushed for the legislation as part of her Let's Move! campaign. The Act was intended to increase access to healthy meals in schools by reauthorizing funding for child nutrition programs and school lunch programs. The updated standards required all school meals to provide larger portions of fruits, vegetables and whole grain foods and lower amounts of salt, as well as zero trans fat. Schools were only permitted to serve low-fat milk, and flavored milks had to be fat-free.

Researchers have praised the legislation. A Harvard School of Public Health study argued that the Healthy, Hunger-Free Kids Act is one of the most important national obesity-prevention policy achievements in recent decades. It estimated that the policy would prevent over two million cases of childhood obesity and save up to 800 million dollars in health care costs over the next ten years.

"We updated the nutrition standards so that now, schools that participate in the national school lunch and school breakfast programs, which are most schools in this country, have to provide healthier school meals," Schwartz said. "We see study after study show that the impact of the law will make a dent in childhood obesity and is helping to decrease health disparities between low-income students that have less access to healthy food and high-income students that have greater access to healthy food."

These nutrition standards were developed in part with the aid of the Center for Science in the Public Interest, where Schwartz works as a senior nutrition policy associate. The Center is a nonprofit watchdog and advocacy group established nearly 45 years ago to work on federal policy issues pertaining to school food, menu labeling, nutrition facts, food safety, funding appropriations and regulatory work.

"We work on improving the food environment so that all Americans can eat better," Schwartz said. "That entails trying to change the food environment from where you go to school to where you work to where you play to where you dine out, as well as changing the foods that are marketed and produced so that consumers can make the easy choice the healthy one, and the healthy choice the easy one."

And at West Haven's only public high school, the healthy choice did become the easy one. Beyl recalls that at West Haven High School, packing a lunch from home was uncommon. Because almost everyone ate school food, students noticed a drastic change in their meals after the passage of the Healthy, Hunger-Free Kids Act.

"We see study after study show that the impact of the law will make a dent in childhood obesity and is helping to decrease health disparities between low-income students."

Before 2014, Beyl often skipped lunch because she disliked the unhealthy food so much. That meant Beyl, and other students who shared her sentiment, were enduring entire school days without a substantial meal.

Then, in response to the Healthy, Hunger-Free Kids Act, West Haven High switched food companies to Sodexo in 2014. The most noteworthy change that followed, especially for vegetarian students like Beyl, was the addition of a salad bar to the lunch line. Food service workers would stand behind the bar and portion veggies into a bowl according to a student's requests, allowing students to build their own salads while ensuring they received balanced amounts of different produce.

> "That's such an important thing to have happened, providing that nutritional literacy resource that used to be nonexistent — I mean, I had heated bagels for five years."

"You had your choice of spinach, iceberg lettuce, romaine lettuce, tomatoes, cucumbers, carrots, peppers, chickpeas, black beans," Beyl remembered fondly. "Then I started finding time to get lunch when we had this option here. Also it's vegetarian, finally I can get something, you know? That was a huge improvement."

Despite the promising improved health outcomes for students, political opposition hindered the Act's momentum. The Obama Administration faced pressure from groups that found the updated nutrition standards too demanding and too rigid—particularly regarding salt.

The Healthy, Hunger-Free Kids Act established sodium targets for school meals that steadily decreased over a ten-year period. In response, the School Nutrition Association, which represents food service professionals and food manufacturers, lobbied to weaken the requirements on the grounds that they were too difficult to meet. If salt drastically and suddenly dropped in school food, lobbyists argued, students would find the food untasty and stop participating in school lunch and breakfast programs.

Indeed, data from the Department of Agriculture shows a one-million-student drop in school lunch program enrollment in 2015. Such a decline would create financial challenges for schools whose funding is dependent on students buying school meals. Big companies frustrated with the costs of having to reformulate recipes and adjust production, like Schwan Food Co., the largest producer of school pizza, also took issue with the administration's sodium reduction targets.

Despite the opposition, schools are already meeting the first sodium-level target according to Schwartz. Companies are also adjusting: Schwan Food, for example, has reformulated its pizza to meet the federal guidelines. Yet, companies continue to lobby Congress to relax those regulations.

The Trump Administration aims to undo the strict regulations from the Obama Administration. The new revisions allow low-fat flavored milk back into schools so that now, students may have one-percent fat chocolate milk in addition to the fat-free chocolate milk required by the Healthy, Hunger-Free Kids Act. Another change postpones the second sodium-level target, originally planned for the 2017-18 school year, to 2021. The third revision expands a waiver program under which schools that have difficulty finding or purchasing pastas, tortillas and breads that are 51 percent or more whole grain can avoid doing so.

According to Schwartz, on a national scale, there is little evidence suggesting that increased food waste has been consequence of the nutrition standards established by the Healthy, Hunger-Free Kids Act.

"Food waste has always been an issue in schools," Schwartz said. "It was an issue before the Healthy Hunger-Free Kids Act, it's still an issue after. Kids just throw away a lot of their food in schools. But the vast majority of studies show that plate waste in schools has either stayed the same or has actually gone down.We see that the vast majority of kids are actually eating more fruits and vegetables, and that means discarding less of their lunches. They're eating more of their entrees as well."

In New Haven, plate waste trends reflect those of the national scale. According to Gail Sharry, executive food service director for New Haven Public Schools, an study conducted in New Haven found that waste levels have not risen following the implementation of the Act.

Student dissatisfaction, however, is a demonstrable concern.

When the Healthy, Hunger-Free Kids Act came into effect, Sharry was the executive food service director of New London Public Schools. She remembers that complaints from students were an issue in the initial years following the updated federal guidelines.

"The kids were more used to white bread and white pasta and white pizza crust, and even rice, we usually used white rice," Sharry said. "Now we use brown rice and whole grain or whole wheat. And at the time…the products weren't the best. The manufacturers were rushed to try to create these products, so they weren't the best quality and we had issues. Like with the brown rice, it either came out very sticky or hard. But now, years later, the rice is awesome. They've figured out how to do it, and they give you the right directions so that you can do it."

Sharry decided to adopt the updated nutrition standards

gradually, so that students and food service employees alike would not be hit all at once with numerous changes. For example, New London schools began serving sandwiches that had half white and half whole-grain bread. These gradual adjustments began a year prior to the passage of the Act, and in conjunction with nutrition education classes provided by Sharry and interns who traveled from classroom to classroom, they made students more receptive toward the new food products.

"Basically, the biggest issue for the kids was the brown, the color of the product, because they weren't used to it," Sharry said. "But once they got used to it, I think year two went a lot easier and the products were a lot better. The manufacturers made changes pretty quickly to fix their product, so that wasn't an issue for us."

The adjustment strategies that Sharry employed in New London seem to have been effective in West Haven as well. Beyl, now an Education Studies Scholar at Yale, emphasizes the value of such nutrition education classes.

"I recall there being demonstrations of healthy eating in lower grades, maybe fourth and fifth grade," Beyl said. "Like, 'Here, let's make a green smoothie,' showing kids how to make a smoothie. That's such an important thing to have happened, providing that nutritional literacy resource that used to be nonexistent—I mean, I had heated bagels for five years."

Beyl remembers that in addition to the salad bar, West Haven High School's switch to Sodexo also added a deli station where students could order a sandwich or wrap. The bread and tortillas were multigrain by default, with no alternatives. According to Beyl, these healthier options were not cause for complaint among West Haven High School students.

"It was just like, 'Oh, cool, we have sandwiches now. Wraps? Neat!' No one even commented on the fact that it was whole wheat," Beyl said. "I mean, just the fact that we had a sandwich was cool because if you didn't want pizza or French fries or what was being offered, you could have other options. And [these options] were super popular. A salad was the thing to get. They were good salads, and they were big salads."

For schools in New London, West Haven and New Haven, the Healthy, Hunger-Free Kids Act ushered in changes that posed administrative challenges and costs initially but have since been well-received. According to Sharry, New Haven will continue abiding by the Act's guidelines. If New Haven were to relax nutrition standards in accordance with the revisions to the Act, the district would have to submit an application to the state Department of Education for approval. Since New Haven students are not complaining about the healthier menus, Sharry sees no reason to undergo the additional administrative and bureaucratic hassle. The revision to the Healthy, Hunger-Free Kids Act that relaxes milk guidelines does not even apply to New Haven, as the district stopped serving any flavored milk nearly a decade ago.

"The kids are accepting our menus as they are right now. And we do know that they are a little bit healthier than before," Sharry said. "And I'd rather stick with that than be lenient just because we can. I don't think we need to do that if we don't have to. I mean, if the students really didn't like the products that we are serving right now, then I might think about it. But right now our participation is pretty good and they like our products."

While some food service directors such as Sharry hope to continue the trajectory of the Healthy, Hunger-Free Kids Act, nutrition policy advocates and analysts worry that the pushback from the Trump Administration will interrupt the momentum championed by the Obama White House.

"The Trump Administration is pulling out all the stops to rollback any protection or public health safeguard at the expense of harming kids' health and thwarting the tremendous progress that schools and companies have made to provide healthier school meals for low-income kids," Schwartz said. "So we need to do everything that we can to maintain the progress."

"The Trump Administration is pulling out all the stops to rollback any protection or public health safeguard at the expense of harming kids' health."

RESILIENCE



PHOTO BY **RITA MAH**

San Francisco Honors World War II's "Comfort Women"

RECOGNIZED

BY **SAMMY WESTFALL**

GLAZED IN BRONZE PATINA, the three girls face outward and hold hands. They look solemn and defiant as they gaze straight ahead, staring over the crowds that form around them. From head to toe, the girls—ages 12 to 18: one Chinese, one Korean, and one Filipina—are no more than 5"2'. But atop the column, they stand twice as tall.

"The raised height of the survivor declares that they will no longer have their story hidden in shame. Instead, their bravery and perseverance demand acknowledgement," Steven Whyte, sculptor of this statue, called "The Women's Column of Strength," told *The Politic.*

The statue, constructed on November 1, 2017 in San Francisco, is one of dozens of public memorials

around the world demanding acknowledgment of the horrific abuse that comfort women suffered in World War II. Several similar statues have been constructed this year in cities ranging from Atlanta to Manila. The euphemism "comfort women" refers to the estimated 80,000 to 200,000 girls and women that the Japanese Imperial Army kept as sex slaves between 1932 and 1945. The majority of comfort women were between 14 and 18 years old and came from Korea, China, the Philippines, and other countries occupied by Japan.

Japanese soldiers abducted the girls from their homes to meet the increasing demand for sex slaves in military camps. During the war, comfort women were detained in state-run camps known as "comfort stations," which consisted of small wooden shacks or tents. The comfort women were sometimes abused by 70 men in one day, according to a 1996 UN report.

Though these atrocities were widespread until the war ended in 1945, the comfort women's plight went largely unacknowledged on an international scale before the 1990s.

That is now beginning to change.

Mary McCarthy, associate professor of political philosophy at Drake University said in an interview with *The Politic* that today, women are "taking agency for themselves and seeking historical justice."

"The women themselves remained silent for decades because of the shame," Judith Mirkinson, president of the the Comfort Women Justice Coalition, echoed in an interview with *The Politic.*

"The irony to me is that if a woman gets raped, it is our fault, it is our shame. But what women are trying to say now, is that this has nothing to do with us," she said. "This is your problem, not our problem."

Advocacy groups like The Comfort Women Justice Coalition (CWJC) hope to end the long period of silence by honoring the women's plight. The group funded the San Francisco sculpture and, in the summer of 2015, invited Mirkinson to help pass a resolution to put up the statue.

"I thought it was going to be very easy, like a no-brainer. Like who could be against a memorial for women who have been sexually enslaved," Mirkinson told *The Politic.* "It turns out to be far different."

The project took two years to complete, and Mirkinson was surprised by how much opposition she met in the process. "It was really a mixed bag because so much of the Japanese-American community supported us, and then there was a faction against us—and they organized," she said.

In addition to opposition from some members of the Japanese-American community in San Francisco, many people in Japan were critical of the statue. Japanese lobbyists and employees of the local Japanese Consulate protested to block the statue's installation. The mayor of Osaka, Hirofumi Yoshimura, even threatened to cut official sisterhood ties with San Francisco because of it, a threat that made national headlines. A spokesperson for Japan's Foreign Ministry called the decision to put up the statue "regrettable and incompatible with the position and efforts of the government of Japan."

"They want to harken back to a time that never existed," Mirkinson said of Japanese opposition to the statue. In her view, there are several reasons for the resistance. "First, they were afraid this would engender and bring up anti-Japanese feelings left over from the war," she said. The second reason, Mirkinson believes, is "a loyalty to the Japanese government, and a feeling that this issue had already been adjudicated."

In an interview with *The Politic,* Kelly Ahn, spokesperson for the Atlanta Comfort Women Memorial Task Force, said opponents misunderstand the purpose of the statue.

"The issue is not about the perpetrating country. To me, the name of the country that perpetrated the sex slavery is almost irrelevant. If the country was named Korea, or the United States, I would still be fighting for a memorial. It just happens to be, in history, the Japanese army,"

Ahn continued, "They try to make it Japan vs. Korea, if they want to get technical with names, then it should be Japan vs. the thirteen nations [reported to house comfort stations]. Ultimately, it is Japan vs. the truth," he said. "And they can't run away from the truth."

Japan has taken many decades to acknowledge the atrocities its soldiers committed against the comfort women. Following decades of outright denials, the Japanese government

"Ultimately, it is Japan vs. the truth," he said. "And they can't run away from the truth."



PHOTO BY **RITA MAH**

acknowledged in 1993 that its imperial army had forced women to work in brothels. In 1995, then-Japanese Prime Minister Tomiichi Murayama offered a broader apology for the "tremendous damage and suffering" caused by Japan during World War II. Still, in 2007, Abe insisted, "The fact is, there is no evidence to prove there was coercion."

Eight years later, Abe pledged to pay 8.3 million dollars in reparations to the dwindling number of comfort women survivors—at last count, fewer than 50 are alive. The effort amounted to a compromise, but not a public apology.

In July 2017, the Atlanta Comfort Women Task Force constructed its own comfort women memorial, which stood 2,530 miles away from the one in San Francisco. Both private citizens and Japanese government-funded news groups opposed the construction. In addition, "dozens and dozens of paid trolls" inundated the comments sections of articles about the statue, and sent emails to every major donor, said Helen Ho, the special adviser to the task force, in an interview with *The Politic*.

The fight over the statue in San Francisco was similarly tenacious.

"Ultimately, what they wanted to do was to stop the statue from going up," Julie Tang, retired California Superior Court judge and co-chairwoman of the CWJC, told *The Politic*. "When they couldn't do that, they worked to destroy its credibility."

Even in the face of resistance, the San Francisco statue resolution won approval, with a vote of 11-0.

Following the go-ahead, the design process moved forward. The coalition opened a memorial proposal design competition to artists, judged by a panel of five San Francisco experts in the fields of activism and public art. They selected the winning design in December 2016: local sculptor Steven Whyte's "Women's Column of Strength," which depicts three young women holding hands.

While the new sculpture is anchored to the comfort women's struggle, Whyte intends for it to honor the lived realities of all victims of sexual violence.

"In approaching the design, I wanted to focus on the following sentiments: vulnerability, resolve, solidarity, resilience, and finally, demand for recognition," Whyte told *The Politic*.

The September 2017 unveiling of the San Francisco comfort women statue coincided with the growth of the #MeToo movement, as part of which women have similarly demanded recognition. Increasingly, victims of Japanese World War II sexual slavery have come forward to speak of the atrocities they survived, to tell their stories, and to seek redress, sometimes decades after crimes were committed against them..

"These [comfort women survivors] whose average age is now 95 years old are the Mothers of the "#MeToo" movement," Tang said. "Their courage to speak up 50 years after the war is a precursor and inspiration to the modern day women who years after their personal sexual trauma start to talk about their own suffering of rapes and sexual assaults."

"Every wave that happens builds on the next one. And then engenders the next one. And the next one," Mirkinson said.

Ahn believes that the comfort women memorial serves a purpose on three levels. First, the memorial honors the victims of World War II sexual slavery. On a deeper level, the statues increase awareness of sexual trafficking, abuse, and violence. But ultimately, Ahn said that he sees the figures as a symbol for the need to safeguard the human rights of all women.

The San Francisco comfort women statue is particularly notable considering the shortage of monuments celebrating women in the city's landscape. Before the memorial's unveiling, only three of San Francisco's 87 public statues depicted women.

"It's really amazing to have a statue to Asian women and girls that talks about their experiences, talks about them as victims and also as survivors, showing women's resilience," said Mirkinson,. "Even after all these horrible experiences, there were women willing to speak out, to not be intimidated, and to say: 'We deserve this.'"

From the ground, a "grandma" figure, in her bronze patina, looks up at the girls on the pedestal. Whyte says her expression is not as "haunted" as those of the young girls. Rather, she looks "at peace, as she looks upon the more recent survivors with resilient power."

"Staring down at visitors to the park, each of the women wears a resolute blank expression and an unyielding gaze," Whyte described. "The viewer sees, in their post-traumatic stare, a look that says, 'Only you can stop this happening again."

"Even after all these horrible experiences, there were women willing to speak out, to not be intimidated, and to say: 'We deserve this.'"



PHOTO BY **FRANK JANG**

TRUTH on TRIAL

Transcribing the Legacy of the Nakba

BY **DANIEL YADIN**

"WHAT THE STATE policy was, everybody knows," he begins.

"What the government decided at the time, everyone knows, yes? To expel as many as possible! That was the government's policy. And at the time I saw nothing wrong with it. We were not mature people. We were kids, and did what we were told. We were also in constant danger. If you don't win, they told us, you won't survive."

So proclaimed an Israeli veteran of the 1948 Arab-Israeli War.

The man gave his testimony before the Truth Commission on the Responsibility of Israeli Society for the Events of 1948-1960 in the South. The Truth Commission, the first of its kind in Israel, was founded in 2012 by the Israeli non-governmental organization Zochrot, pronounced *zokh-rote*, the *kh* making a guttural sound at the back of the throat. Zochrot's stated mission is to "promote acknowledgement and accountability for the ongoing injustices of the Nakba, the Palestinian catastrophe of 1948."

In Hebrew, "zochrot" means "remember." It is not a command—remember!—but a present-tense descriptor with a feminine plural subject: *we remember, you remember, they remember.* In Hebrew, the convention is to default to the masculine ("zochrim"). Zochrot's name reflects a self-proclaimed rejection of the masculine, violent historical narrative.

Since its founding in 1948, the State of Israel has had to contend "with the preceding layer of its existence, a layer that it has erased and on which it has been built," according to Jewish Israeli researcher Noga Kadman's book *Erased from Space and Consciousness: Israel and the Depopulated Palestinian Villages of 1948*. The 1948 War,

triggered by Israel's May 14 declaration of its establishment and the subsequent Arab response, was fought between Israel and a coalition of neighboring Arab states. The nine-month-long conflict displaced nearly a million Palestinians, either internally or as refugees to neighboring countries, and at least 418 Palestinian villages were depopulated. This was the Nakba, Arabic for "catastrophe."

The history of the Nakba is the subject of fierce debate in Israel and around the world. At the center of this debate is the extent to which Israeli forces intentionally expelled Palestinians, the role of neighboring Arab states in necessitating or encouraging Palestinian flight, and the existence of a pre-Nakba Palestinian identity. Often, though, the Nakba itself goes unmentioned.

Israel's political parties might be helpful in illuminating how the Nakba is remembered, or erased, across different segments of Israeli society. A search for "Nakba" on the Hebrew websites of various parties yields results that range from outright opposition to omission to support. The word appears once on the website of the right-wing ruling Likud Party, in the transcript of a 2014 speech from Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu against the Palestinian Authority's "incessant incitement…reflected in the fact that they hold processions on what they call the 'Nakba'…defining the existence and establishment of the State of Israel as a disaster that must be corrected." A search on the website of the left-wing opposition Labor Party yields zero results, and the far-left Meretz Party displays eight results, linking to pages describing party policy, historical fact sheets, and statements of principle. Acceptance of the Nakba as historical fact remains a feature of the Israeli far left, where Zochrot comfortably sits.

With its Truth Commission, Zochrot seeks to establish a historical, testimonial archive of the Nakba. Doing so places the group squarely at the nerve center of Israeli society: By attempting transitional justice for a still-raging conflict, the group seeks to challenge what it sees as Israel's carefully constructed collective memory.

"It can be traumatic to understand what happened here," Kadman told *The Politic*. "What happened on the land that I live in today, what happened to people who were killed, who lost everything, who were dispossessed."

Israel has mostly dealt with the legacy of Palestine by forgetting it, Kadman argues in Erased from Space and Consciousness. According to Kadman's account, the Israeli government strives to erase the legacy of the land's pre-1948 inhabitants by demolishing vacant Arab villages, converting them into apolitical historical attractions, and Hebraizing remaining Arab place names.

These efforts are intimately tied to the battle over Israel's collective memory, defined generally by Kadman as "stories that a group tells itself about its history, something that is constantly being built and shaped normatively by the hegemonic ruling class." Dominant Israeli narratives rarely center on the Nakba; Kadman summarized them as "we won and established our state, and the things that happened in wars happened, and Palestinians became refugees and they escaped, and this is now our country." The Ministry of Foreign Affairs, in its online timeline of Israeli history, makes no mention of the event.

The Truth Commission works against erasure. Jessica Nevo, a curly-haired Argentine immigrant who coordinates the Truth Commision, was one of the Commission's earliest advocates within Zochrot.

In 1976, when Nevo was 14 years old and living in Buenos Aires, the Argentine military overthrew President Isabel Perón in a coup and installed General Jorge Rafael Videla in her stead. Two years later, Nevo and her family left Buenos Aires for Israel. They decided to migrate because of the new regime, which "made disappear, tortured, and killed members of my family," she said in a 2004 speech before Badil, a Palestinian rights NGO.

"[Living] almost all my life under state terrorism, military checkpoints and curfews has had an impact on my adopting a critical perspective to the conflict [in Israel]," Nevo told the audience.

The similarities she perceived between Israel and Argentina's national traumas gave Nevo hope that Argentina's post-dictatorship mechanisms of truth-seeking, commemoration, and justice could succeed in Israel.

Zochrot's Truth Commission draws inspiration from the National Commission on the Disappearance of Persons (CONADEP), established in Argentina in 1984, the year after the fall of the military dictatorship.

ISRAEL HAS MOSTLY DEALT WITH THE LEGACY OF PALESTINE BY

FORGETTING IT

THE SECOND PAGE CLARIFIES, FOLLOWING A COPYRIGHT SYMBOL, THAT

"ALL RIGHTS ARE RESERVED TO THOSE WHO WERE EXPELLED FROM THEIR HOMES."

CONADEP was the first truth commission of its kind, and its task was, in Nevo's words, "to establish the truth about the fate of the disappeared." The commission worked for nine months. Its final report, *Nunca Más*—Never Again—named the disappeared, published the testimonies of survivors and their families, and documented the junta's systematic repression of Argentine society.

During her 2004 speech before Badil, Nevo predicted that a truth commission on the Nakba could "end up putting the whole Zionist project on trial."

The trial began in 2012. In October of that year, Zochrot hosted in its Tel Aviv gallery *Towards a Common Archive*, a media exhibition curated by filmmaker Eyal Silvan and historian Ilan Pappé that presented testimonies of thirty Jewish fighters from the 1948 War. According to Zochrot's final report, the event illuminated the need for a larger, organized effort to document testimony about 1948.

Shortly thereafter, Zochrot established a steering committee to develop the framework for a truth commission about the Nakba. The members of the steering committee could draw inspiration from many international models: Since CONADEP published *Nunca Más* in 1984, truth commissions have been established in over thirty nations, most famously in post-apartheid South African and post-genocide Rwanda.

Despite several delays, the preliminary steering committee eventually gave way to a formal commission, which began its research in October of 2014 and chose to focus its work on the south of Israel. As the Commission wrote in its final report, "the project's preliminary and semi-experimental nature" made studying the whole of the Nakba—a behemoth task for any group—impossible.

Focusing exclusively on the events in Israel's south also served political purposes. The Nakba is best remembered in the center and north of Israel—in the Galilee, the Sharon Plain, Jerusalem and its environs—where the displacement of Palestinians registers, for those who choose to acknowledge it, as a historical event.

The displacement of the Bedouin Arabs of the Negev Desert, which stretches over most of the south of Israel, is a less-recognized part of the Nakba. Walid Khalidi did not include Bedouin communities in the list of 418 depopulated Palestinian villages in his 1992 book *All That Remains*. Kadman, drawing off Khalidi's work, excludes Bedouin sites from study in *Erased from Space and Consciousness: Israel and the Depopulated Palestinian Villages of 1948*. Focusing the efforts of the Truth Commission on the south of Israel, then, was an attempt to bring the Bedouin experience into the memory of the Nakba.

By the end of 2014, Zochrot was ready to host the first public hearing of the Truth Commission. It took place on International Human Rights Day, December 10, in a gray-walled and colorfully-carpeted conference room in the southern city of Be'er Sheva. Over two hundred people attended, including two classes of high schoolers from Tel Aviv and Jaffa.

The testimonies delivered at the first hearing reflected the broader conflict over what, exactly, happened in 1948. Nuri al-Uqbi, a Bedouin witness, testified that the Israeli Army expelled his family from the Negev, "The Jews came to our large tent...and said that within four hours they did not want to see anyone here. 'Go east of the Jordan River.'"

Another Bedouin man, identified by the last name abu-Ashiva, described in detail the evacuation of his community.

"The killings and murders began in the north, then moved westward, and then they came to al-Sab'a," abu-Ashiva said. "The city surrendered quickly, without war or resistance. The urban women were running barefoot, and the blood dripped from their legs...and then they drove the men to the [West] Bank."

Most Israeli veterans did not blame their own forces for the violence.

Before the Truth Commission, Amnon Neumann spoke of his encounter with a comrade during the 1948 War.

"A man came," he began, "and said, 'I raped her, and I shot her.' She was seventeen or eighteen, I don't know. I went to the commander of his platoon, and told him that he should be executed."

But, Neumann hastened to clarify, "he was not a son of this land... *We* didn't do anything wrong!"

Similarly, the Israeli veteran Zalman Arzi defiantly testified that he "would be ready to apologize if [he] felt that [he] had done something not fit."

Al-Uqbi and Neumann agreed on one point, though: The Truth Commission had a slim chance of effecting change. They made sure their thoughts on the matter entered the testimonial record.

Neumann concluded his testimony by announcing that he believed the organization "cannot solve the problems" it seeks to address, and al-Uqbi concurred.

"This is not a commission. It has no authority. If a day comes when a real trial takes place with an accused, a prosecutor, and a judge, I'll say things much more serious than what I said today," al-Uqbi said.

The two raise a salient point. Zochrot remains a small fringe group in Israel, relegated to the outer orbit of the Israeli Left at a time when the right wing enjoys unprecedented political and cultural dominance. Its ability to make change is limited by the bounds of public and official discourse.

The Israeli state actively suppresses memory of the Nakba. The "Nakba Law," which allows the Finance Minister to withhold state funding from any institution that celebrates Israel's Independence Day as a day of mourning, or Nakba Day, has caused legal repercussions against commemoration of the Nakba. In 2014, the University of Haifa expelled two Arab students for organizing political activity on campus on the anniversary of the Nakba (this decision was later canceled by a district court), violating the school's ban on Nakba Day commemorations instituted after the law's passage in 2011. Culture and Sports Minister Miri Regev recently called for the government to use the law to fine the Tel Aviv Cinematheque for hosting a film festival about the Nakba, organized by Zochrot.

"Crimes are still being executed today," Kadman said. "Israeli society is not in the state that this commission could have any momentum...A lot needs to happen. We need to look at history with more open eyes and in a balanced way, to see the other, to hear the other."

A YEAR AFTER the opening event came the commission's closing, under two tents in the Bedouin village of al-Araqib. The Israeli government does not recognize the locality, meaning al-Araqib lacks basic services like electricity and water and is regularly demolished by the state. In the program, Zochrot encouraged attendees to consult its iNakba app to find the village, which is not on Google Maps. During the two-day closing ceremony, Zochrot ran an aerial photography workshop, held an event to document artifacts for a digital archive of al-Araqib, and released the final report of the Truth Commission.

The English version of the report is thirty pages long, and contains excerpts of testimony and several pages of background and analysis. Its cover features, in large yellow block letters, the name of the document in English and Arabic. The second page clarifies, following a copyright symbol, that "all rights are reserved to those who were expelled from their homes."

Jessica Nevo delivered the opening address of the event. She spoke, in her Argentine-accented Hebrew, of the role Zochrot could play in Israeli society.

"Truth commissions in the world, processes of transitional justice, processes of coping with the past and the acceptance of responsibility, are not to add salt to a wound," Nevo said, "but to heal the wound. To place a salve."

Three months after the January 2 event, in March of 2016, the Truth Commission on the Responsibility of Israeli Society for the Events of 1948-1960 in the South submitted its final report to the United Nations Rapporteur on the Right to Truth, Reparation, and Guarantee of Non-Recurrence.

Three months later, after the tents specially erected for Zochrot's closing event had come down, after the Truth Commission's report was placed safely in the hands of a United Nations bureaucrat, after the truth of 1948 had been excavated and preserved and publicly declared, the Israeli government demolished al-Araqib for the 100th time.

Village leader Siyah al-Touri told Al Jazeera that the army "stormed in and destroyed everything, every single building, every single home."

The truth was no salve.

THE TRUTH WAS NO SALVE.



PHOTO BY **IVY FAN**

Legal-ize It?

Connecticut Grapples with Marijuana Law

Read Street in New Haven, where police stopped Marcus Price in 1995.

BY **CHLOE KIMBALL**

ON A LATE NIGHT in October of 1995, 15-year-old Marcus Price was strolling down his block in New Haven when he was stopped by a pair of white cops.

The baggy pockets of his black army pants were stuffed with 1,200 dollars and enough marijuana to rake in a few hundred more. But it wasn't the pockets that gave him away.

"I was on a drug block," Price told *The Politic*. "I should've known I'd be stopped and taken in."

As Price was handcuffed and driven down to the station, he wasn't wracked by fear of punishment. At the time, he considered the arrest a rite of passage. In his young mind, a drug dealer had all the markers of a hero: money, grit, and defiance towards the powers that be.

It was his first offense, so Price got off with a sentence of three years probation. But the probation did little to impact his mindset.

"I didn't change or anything," Price explained. "My probation officer went on vacation right after the case and I never heard from her again," he continued. "So I just continued as I had."

Emboldened by the laxity of his first encounter with the law, Price started selling crack cocaine and soon found himself in competitive skirmishes with other dealers as each tried to assert his territory. For a while, the brushes remained relatively harmless, like when he stole another dealer's dirt bike. But at 17, Price got himself involved in an armed fight. And this time, he was charged with assault in the first degree.

In any court case, if a jury returns a guilty verdict, then a judge must sentence the defendant. Judges have broad discretion in sentencing, though they must take into account prosecutorial recommendations and mandatory minimums and maximums, which dictate the prison time that can be set for a particular crime. Price's judge could have sentenced him to any amount of time between five and 20 years, according to the sentencing restrictions for his crime.

In 1997, seventeen-year-old Price, a minor, was sentenced to the full 20 years in prison.

"I got the maximum because of my previous offenses," he speculated.

Advocates of marijuana legalization might seize upon Price's experience as an example of prohibition perpetuating America's incarceration crisis. Were marijuana use legal and his record clean, perhaps Price would not have been imprisoned past the age of 22. Instead, he was released just last year, at 37.

In Connecticut, 2018 gubernatorial candidates are wrestling with the issue of marijuana legalization. While some fiercely support legalization for fiscal and social reasons, others note potential health and safety risks. Disagreements aside, most candidates recognize that the War

on Drugs, and the attendant War on Marijuana, have disproportionately targeted communities of color. While some legalization advocates hope that a new policy will undo the legacy of discriminatory drug laws, racial justice has not been given the level of attention afforded to the public health and fiscal elements of this debate.

The Connecticut legislature has continually relaxed the state's marijuana restrictions. In 2011, Hartford approved marijuana decriminalization, which means that possession of marijuana under certain amounts cannot lead to prison time, nor to a criminal record for a first-time offense. In effect, small amounts of marijuana possession are treated as traffic violations—still illegal, but not criminal. Legalization, on the other hand, would make marijuana use non-criminal. In 2012 and 2014, the state moved to legalize a medical marijuana program and the industrial hemp industry.



PHOTO BY **IVY FAN**

Despite the spate of reforms, Governor Dannel Malloy (D) remains staunchly in opposition to recreational legalization. During his tenure, efforts to legalize recreational use among adults failed to pass the state legislature. Other states that have legalized recreational use have done so through ballot initiatives, allowing voters to make the decisions. Connecticut, however, has no such ballot process. Legalization would require the state legislature's support and the governor's stamp. But with Malloy's decision not to run for reelection in 2018, legalization advocates see an opening.

At the same time, the state's fiscal crisis might increase advocates' chances of success. Despite having the highest per capita income of any state in the union, Connecticut is on the verge of bankruptcy, with a 200 million dollar deficit in 2017 compounding the state's two billion dollars of public debt. As Riley Tillitt '19 of Students for Sensible Drug Policy explained to *The Politic,* marijuana legalization has become a hot-button issue for many candidates, in large part because a newly-taxable marijuana market could help close that gap. The Connecticut Office of Fiscal Management estimates the market would increase tax revenues by 100 million dollars annually. In addition, the state would no longer have to spend taxpayer funds to arrest and prosecute marijuana offenders.

There is also a fiscal spillover concern. Because Massachusetts recently legalized recreational marijuana, some Connecticut residents are spending their money at dispensaries across state lines. According to Paul Armentano of the National Organization for the Reform of Marijuana Laws (NORML), "You are going to have Connecticut residents spending their dollars in Massachusetts and that doesn't benefit Connecticut. It'll be to the benefit of Massachusetts, who is the first to the finish line."

While the spillover concern, fiscal crisis, and gubernatorial shake-up play to advocates' interest, the Trump Administration's recent announcement that it will begin enforcing the federal prohibition of marijuana casts a cloud over the otherwise bright prospect of Connecticut's legalization.

According to Yale Law School professor Steven Duke,

the chances of a federal crackdown seem unlikely. "My expectation is that the enforcement of federal marijuana laws will not change as a result of that statement," he told *The Politic*. "Sessions does not have the muscle, nor does Trump, to reverse what has been happening in the last ten years or so."

IN DECEMBER 2017, the first statewide gubernatorial debate on the topic of marijuana reform took place. Co-hosted by the Students for Sensible Drug Policy at Yale and the Connecticut Branch of NORML, the event featured four of the almost twenty declared gubernatorial candidates. Former Middletown mayor Dan Drew (D), former commissioner of consumer protection Jonathan Harris (D), state representative Prasad Srinivasan (R), and purple heart recipient Micah Welintukonis (I) addressed a series of topics, ranging from the state's nascent medical marijuana program and the opioid epidemic to the issue of recreational legalization.

The beginning of the debate focused on the medical marijuana program, which opponents characterize as overly cautious, exclusionary, and monopolistic. As debate moderator Aaron Romano of NORML said, the program's costly licensing process requires the availability of serious amounts of capital to which very few firms have access. Moreover, only certain medical conditions, such as cancer, are included in the program, while opioid addiction is not. Medical marijuana is not covered by insurance.

According to Armentano, legalization allows doctors to recommend that patients buy their product through dispensaries, in the same way doctors might recommend patients stop by the drug store for Advil. This change, he said, might solve some of the limitations endemic to the medical marijuana program.

Out of the four panelists, Drew emerged as the strongest advocate of legalization for recreational adult use. Drew emphasized legalization as a means to protect vulnerable groups: opioid addicts, low-income communities, and people of color. According to Drew, states that have legalized marijuana for recreational use have seen overdoses drop by roughly 25 percent.

At the same time, the candidates recognized that marijuana legalization could help undo the War on Drugs, which has persisted in Connecticut for decades. Connecticut has one of the highest increases in racial disparities for marijuana possession arrest rates, according to a study conducted by the American Civil Liberties Union. In 2001, black people were 2.2 times more likely than white people to be arrested for marijuana possession, despite the fact that both races used marijuana at similar rates. By 2010, that figure jumped to 3.3 times more likely. Certain counties were particularly egregious. In Middlesex and Litchfield, for example, black possession arrests were found to be seven and eight times higher than white possession arrests. But the candidates were less concerned with race than with opioid addiction.

Commissioner Harris, who oversaw the rollout of the medical program during his tenure, was more tepid in his support of recreational legalization. While he agreed that Connecticut should consider medical marijuana as potentially helpful in combating the opioid epidemic (which he revealed affected his family), he emphasized that the state should deal with legalization in a "thoughtful and deliberate" manner.

Sitting at the far end of the panel, anti-establishment and unaffiliated candidate Welintukonis counterposed Harris's insider status. His opening remarks included a quip over his no-shave-November beard and some dry mockery of Hartford's "political B.S." In line with his "common man" brand, Welintukonis got straight to the point.

"Yeah, so I'm for pot," he announced with a smirk, eliciting a chorus of giggles from the crowd.

Still, it seemed as though he was repeating, albeit in a watered-down fashion, the supportive points brought up by Mayor Drew.

Srinivasan, the lone Republican on the panel, expressed his party's general disapproval of legalization efforts. Specifically, Srinivasan claimed that the expectations of significant tax revenue are overblown—where debt runs in the billions, a hundred million or so extra dollars will be a drop in the bucket at best.

But his main point was the potential public and social health costs. Among opponents, there is widespread concern that a legal profit-driven market could increase the use of marijuana products.

Opponents also worry about marijuana users driving while under the influence. Unlike with alcohol, where a breathalyzer test immediately determines one's level of intoxication, no such technology exists for marijuana. Duke believes that there is no proof of cause and effect between marijuana intoxication and fatal accidents.

"Drivers under the influence of marijuana are aware that they are impaired and most of them, unless they are drunk on alcohol, will compensate for their impairment by driving more slowly," he said. "Whereas people high on alcohol are not aware of the extent of their impairment and that's why they kill so many people."

That the first statewide gubernatorial debate focused on marijuana reform seems to presuppose that marijuana policy has been a top concern among candidates. In reality, however, it seems that the debate itself brought marijuana policy into the spotlight. The event triggered a wave of attention from the media and provoked responses from other candidates.

Just hours after the panel discussion ended, for example, Libertarian candidate Mark Stewart posted a video on YouTube outlining his full-throttled support for legalizing recreational adult use. In an interview with *The Politic*, Stewart promised that, if elected, he would legalize recreational use by 2020.

Democratic candidate Lee Whitnum told *The Politic* that she also favors legalization to aid with the budgetary and opioid crises. "Unlike synthetic opioids that come from a lab in New Jersey, marijuana is an all-natural product and not physically addictive," she explained.

The recent push for legalization comes too late to make a difference for Marcus Price. When Price was released at age 37, he needed a job.

"I'm using the same hustling mentality from when I was selling drugs, but this time I'm getting jobs," he said. "I just slept for 20 years so I don't care about sleep these days. I'll get two jobs, three jobs, whatever it takes to succeed."

These days he works at a Dunkin Donuts in Hamden by day, but serves as a mentor by night.

When Price was in prison upstate, he co-founded a program called Skills of Socialization, or SOS, through which he mentored youth who were involved with drugs. He urged them to find new paths and to avoid the types of 20-year sentences imposed on those, like him, who continued to deal drugs despite a first warning.

"The program worked wonders for young men," Price said. "They are the most important because they don't have the kind of [sentences] that we had. So we have an opportunity to show them what you can potentially be if you don't change your act today. You have to own up to what you did so you don't become like us."

Still, SOS does not have a one hundred-percent success rate. One young SOS graduate was living at Price's halfway house when he began dealing again. When the behavior came to Price's attention, he pulled the young man aside. "I told him I wasn't disappointed, but that he should be disappointed in himself," Price said. "Just a day later he was back on his feet and thanking me. His caseworker came to me and asked how I did it. I said no disrespect, but at the end of the day I can do your job better than you because I can relate."

As candidates and advocates tout marijuana legalization as a vital reform, those like Price who have experienced incarceration firsthand see the marijuana issue as only part of the solution. Had marijuana been legalized by 1995, Price might not have preferred a low-paying dispensary job to making hundreds of dollars a day on the street. Similarly, if marijuana is legalized in 2018, it might not dramatically change the prospects of the young man in Price's halfway house.

THE FULL DECRIMINALIZATION of marijuana remains a critical first step in dismantling America's War on Drugs, a policy that persists in Connecticut. For Price, however, America must reassess its priorities if legalization is to effectively undo the legacy of punitive drug laws.

In Price's mind, the belief that legalization will remedy decades of racist drug policies is overblown. Price worries that the current debate focuses too much on legalization's fiscal benefits and public health improvements. Legalization efforts in Connecticut prioritize tax revenue and an improved healthcare system, but they might overlook the Marcus Prices of the world.



PHOTO BY **IVY FAN**

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Breaking Bread, Breaking Barriers: Refugees Share Their Cultures Through Culinary Diplomacy

BY **NOAH KOPF '21**

For some refugees, the best way to preserve and share their cultures is through an ancient medium: food. Noah Kopf '21 writes about how culinary diplomacy helps integrate new residents into existing communities.

Black Gold: Curbing Demand for Drugs in the Golden Triangle

BY **SARAH STROBER '20**

Beside tourist resorts advertising elephant rides and massive Chinese-funded casinos, Thailand, Laos, and Myanmar meet in the middle of the rushing Mekong River. The seemingly tranquil region surrounding the intersection is home to one of the world's largest drug production zones. Sarah Strober '20 investigates the supply and demand of opioids and methamphetamines in Southeast Asia.

Drawing the Line: Redistricting in Pennsylvania's 15th District

BY **ASHA PRIHAR '21**

Asha Prihar '21 navigates the chaos of Pennsylvania's 15th district. In late January, the state's Supreme Court ruled that Pennsylvania's congressional districts be redrawn. Now, uncertainty looms over the normally uncontested congressional election in the 15th district. With both the district map and partisan control no longer certain, everything is up for grabs.

The Curious Melancholy of Ladybird: How conceptions of melancholia have changed in film and culture

BY **GABBY COLANGELO '21**

From 17-century humoral theories to Freudian psychology, melancholy has long been a subject of study. Depictions of the feeling in film—particularly, in the 1939 movie adaptation of Wuthering Heights and in last year's Lady Bird—show changing conceptions of the feeling. For The Sophist, The Politic*'s philosophy platform, Gabby Colangelo '21 analyzes instances of melancholia in select works, and asks: When we mourn the past, are we wasting the present?*

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The MacMillan Report

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